

JUROR NINE

Smitty's



By Ralph M. Butler and Opus 4.6



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Chapter 1 — The Nashville Thing

The phone rang at seven-forty on a Tuesday morning, which meant it was the other line. Dan kept two — the university cell in its case on the kitchen counter, the prepaid in the drawer beside the coffee filters. He dried his hands on the dish towel and answered.

“How’s Nashville?”

“Warm,” Dan said.

“Getting warmer. Listen, something came across my desk. Local to you, which I know isn’t ideal.”

“It’s not.”

“I understand that. But the client’s in a bind and the timeline is tight. Two weeks, maybe three.”

Dan poured coffee into a mug that said UTK HISTORY DEPARTMENT on the side. A gift from a former colleague in Knoxville he’d stayed in touch with. “Who’s the client?”

“Real estate. Development outfit, Nashville-based. They’ve got a project held up by a city planning commissioner who won’t play ball. Commissioner’s name is Boone. Travis Boone.”

“Held up how?”

“Some historic preservation issue. The commissioner found something in the record — old building on the development site, civil rights era, apparently significant enough to freeze the permits. Client’s been trying to work around it for six months. Lawyers, lobbyists, the usual. Boone won’t budge.”

“And now they want him gone.”

“They want the problem solved. Boone is the problem.”

Dan took his coffee to the window. His apartment was on the third floor of a converted Victorian in Hillsboro Village, close enough to campus that he walked most days. The street below was quiet. A woman was loading a cello into the back of a Subaru.

“What’s the setup look like?”

“Boone lives alone. No wife, no kids. Parents are in Murfreesboro, he sees them on Sundays. Routine is predictable — office, city hall, a couple of restaurants he likes. Drives a gray Tacoma. I’ll send you the full packet.”

“Fee?”

“Seventy-five. Half up front.”

“For a local job, that’s light.”

“I mentioned that. Client says seventy-five is firm.”

“Client doesn’t get to be firm. Local means risk to my long-term setup. Tell them ninety or find someone who doesn’t live here.”

A pause on the other end. Not long. “I’ll relay that. Anything else?”

“The development outfit — how many people know why they’re calling you?”

“One. The principal. Everyone else thinks they’re still trying lawyers.”

“Keep it that way.”

“Always do. I’ll be in touch.”

The line went dead. Dan set the phone back in the drawer, next to a box of number-four filters and a spare battery. He finished his coffee standing at the window, watching the cellist pull away from the curb.

Ninety was fair for a local job. He’d done two others in Tennessee over the years, both in Memphis, both clean, both far enough from Nashville that the geography didn’t connect. This would be different. Same city, same circles — not overlapping, but adjacent. A planning commissioner. The kind of person whose absence gets noticed, whose disappearance generates news coverage and dedicated detectives.

He rinsed the mug and set it in the rack. Picked up the university phone from the counter and checked his email. Three messages from students, one from the department chair, one from the university library about an inter-library loan he’d requested — a dissertation on African American music venues in the mid-South, 1945 to 1968. He’d ordered it two weeks ago for his own research, before he’d ever heard the name Travis Boone.

He noted the coincidence and let it go.

The lecture hall in Furman was half-full, which for a Tuesday-Thursday eleven o'clock on the Cold War was better than average. Dan had twenty-six students enrolled and maybe eighteen who showed up with any regularity. The rest appeared for exams and the occasional extra-credit screening.

He'd spent the hour on the Berlin Crisis of 1961 — Khrushchev's ultimatum, Kennedy's response, the wall going up overnight in August. He liked teaching this unit. The material had a clean architecture to it: two rational actors making increasingly irrational decisions because the system they'd built left no room for retreat. You laid out the documents, you showed the timeline, and you let twenty-year-olds sit with the fact that the world nearly ended over a city most of them couldn't find on a map.

"All right," Dan said, closing his laptop. "Thursday we'll pick up with the aftermath — the tank standoff at Checkpoint Charlie and the shift in NATO strategy that followed. Read the Kempe chapter. All of it, not just the parts that showed up on the study guide last year."

A hand went up in the third row. Tyler Beckham, a junior who'd maintained a consistent C-minus through a combination of confidence and guesswork.

"Professor Mercer, I had a question about today's material."

"Go ahead."

"So when the wall went up — did we try to stop it? Because I feel like Kennedy should have just said no, right?"

Dan looked at him. Beckham leaned back in his chair, satisfied, a baseball cap turned backwards on his head.

"That's what we spent the last twenty minutes on," Dan said. "The administration's decision not to intervene militarily and the reasoning behind it."

"Right, no, I know. I just meant, like, couldn't we have just told them to take it down?"

“We covered the strategic calculus. Kennedy determined that a wall was preferable to a war. It was in the slideshow.”

“Oh.” Beckham looked at his laptop screen as if the slideshow might still be there. “I might have missed that part.”

“It’s in the Kempe reading too.” Dan gathered his notes. “Thursday, everyone.”

The hall emptied in the usual way — the engaged students first, already talking to each other, then the middle tier checking their phones, then the stragglers who’d been asleep or close to it. Dan packed his bag and walked out through the side door into the corridor.

The history department occupied the second floor of Furman Hall, a 1920s building with high ceilings and radiators that still worked better than the air conditioning. Dan’s office was at the far end, past the main office where Sheila, the department coordinator, managed the copy machine and the faculty mailbox slots with equal authority.

He passed her on the way to Dr. Alderman’s office. She was sorting mail.

“Dan. You get your jury summons sorted out?”

“That’s where I’m headed.”

“Good luck. Ray hates rearranging the coverage schedule.”

Dr. Raymond Alderman had been department chair for six years, long enough to have perfected the expression of a man being asked to do something inconvenient. His door was open. He was eating a sandwich at his desk, a napkin tucked into his collar.

“Ray, you have a minute?”

Alderman waved him in with the sandwich. “If it’s about the spring symposium, I already told Patterson we’re not funding a second keynote.”

“It’s not. I got a jury summons. Davidson County. Reporting date’s the middle of next month — I wanted to get on your calendar before you built the coverage schedule.”

Alderman set the sandwich down. “How long?”

“Could be a day if I don’t get picked. Could be a week or more if I do.”

“You’re teaching the eleven o’clock?”

“Just the one section. I can leave them the Kempe readings and a short essay assignment. If it goes longer than a week, I’ll set up the Cuba documentary with discussion questions. Sheila can unlock the screening room.”

Alderman thought about it. Which meant he was calculating whether any of this would create a problem he’d have to solve personally.

“Fine,” he said. “Let me know if it goes past two weeks. At that point I’ll need to bring in someone to cover.”

“Appreciated.”

“You try to get out of it?”

“Not very hard.”

“Most people would.”

Dan shrugged. “I don’t mind. Change of scenery.”

Alderman picked his sandwich back up. “Scenery. You’ll be sitting in a room with eleven strangers arguing about whether someone ran a red light.”

“Could be interesting.”

“It never is.”

Dan left him to his lunch. In the hallway, Sheila caught his eye and raised an eyebrow. He gave her a small nod — handled — and kept walking.

Outside, the campus was bright and warm, students crossing between buildings with the distracted purpose of people headed to their next obligation. A grounds crew was edging the walkways. Somewhere behind Furman, a maintenance cart beeped in reverse.

Dan walked to the faculty lot. He was fifty-two and looked it in the right light — gray coming in at the temples, lines around the eyes that deepened when he squinted, which in Nashville was most of the year. He kept his hair trimmed close and his face clean-shaven and wore what every mid-career academic in the building wore: khakis, a button-down open at the collar, a

canvas jacket when the morning was cool enough to justify one. He was lean, medium height, with the build of someone who ran three mornings a week and didn't do much else — which was close enough to true. Nothing about him would make you look twice. He'd spent a long time making sure of that.

He drove a ten-year-old Volvo wagon, dark blue, unremarkable in every way a car can be unremarkable. He'd bought it from a retired English professor who'd kept it garaged. Eighty thousand miles on the odometer and not a single memorable feature. The car matched the man, which was also the point.

He sat in the driver's seat and didn't start the engine. The packet on Travis Boone would be waiting in the secure drop by tonight — a P.O. box in Brentwood he kept under a name that existed only on a driver's license and a utility bill. He'd pick it up after dark, review it at the apartment, and start his preliminary work this week. Address, patterns, daily route. The usual.

The jury summons was on his kitchen counter, under a magnet from the Tennessee State Museum.

Two problems, both manageable. The contract would take two weeks of preparation and then one clean evening. The jury duty would take a day, maybe two — he'd answer the questions blandly, present as a mildly bored academic, and either get seated on something trivial or get sent home.

He started the Volvo and pulled out of the lot. At the light on West End, he turned toward Hillsboro Village, the campus shrinking in his mirror. A block later he was thinking about Travis Boone's gray Tacoma, the Sunday visits to Murfreesboro, the restaurants he liked. The ordinary architecture of an ordinary life, which Dan would spend the next two weeks learning well enough to dismantle.

He turned the radio on. WMOT was playing Coltrane. He left it there.

Chapter 2 — The Packet

The P.O. box in Brentwood was in a strip mall between a dry cleaner and a nail salon, the kind of place where nobody looked at anyone. Dan pulled into the lot at nine-fifteen, after full dark. Three other cars, none occupied. He left the Volvo running, went in with the alias key, and came out with a padded mailer. Half a pound, maybe less.

Back at the apartment, he cleared the kitchen table and opened the envelope with a paring knife. Standard packet: two photographs, a one-page bio summary, home address, vehicle registration, workplace address, and a short section on known associates and daily patterns. The broker's people were reliable. Not creative, but thorough.

The photographs were recent. Travis Boone stood outside what looked like city hall — tall, maybe six-one, with broad shoulders that hadn't come from a gym. He had the build of someone who'd worked with his hands earlier in life and kept the frame without keeping the labor. Dark hair cut short, a square jaw, and deep-set eyes that looked directly at the camera in one shot and off to the left in another. Mid-thirties or early forties, hard to pin exactly. In the second photo he was talking to someone on the sidewalk, one hand raised in a gesture that could have been emphasis or refusal. His posture said he wasn't backing up.

Dan pinned both photos to the corkboard above his desk in the spare bedroom — the room he kept locked when colleagues came over for the department's annual start-of-semester gathering. He studied the bio. Commissioner since 2019. Before that, six years in urban planning with the city. Before that, a degree from Middle Tennessee State. No military, no law enforcement, no criminal record. A clean and unremarkable public servant who'd found something in a permit review and hadn't let go.

The home address was in East Nashville — a neighborhood that had been rough twenty years ago and was now coffee shops and renovation projects. The vehicle was the gray Tacoma the broker had mentioned. Known associates were sparse: colleagues at city hall, a few friends the surveillance team had noted, and the parents in Murfreesboro.

Dan memorized the address and the daily pattern summary, then locked the packet in the desk drawer with the rest of his operational materials — a second prepaid phone, still in its packaging, a set of Tennessee plates registered to nobody, and a nine-millimeter Glock in a foam-lined case he hadn't opened in eight months.

He started the next morning. Drove to city hall and parked on the opposite block, nose out, coffee from a gas station on the seat beside him. At seven-fifty a gray Tacoma pulled into the employee lot and Travis Boone stepped out.

He was taller in person than the photos suggested. Long stride, in no hurry, a messenger bag over one shoulder. He wore chinos and a button-down with the sleeves rolled to the forearms — no tie, no jacket. His arms were tan and ropy. He walked like a man who expected to get where he was going without interference, which was either confidence or habit. Dan watched him badge in at the side entrance, exchange a word with a security guard, and disappear inside.

Dan adjusted his side mirror and let the seat take his weight. This was the part of the work most people wouldn't understand — the patience of it. Hours in a parked car with nothing happening, watching a building and waiting for a man to come back out. Dan was good at it. He'd been good at it for a long time. His fingers drummed once on the steering wheel and went still, the engine off. He watched the lot and the street and the entrance and let his breathing slow until the car felt like an extension of the sidewalk.

By eleven, Travis came out for what looked like an early lunch — walked two blocks to a taco place, ate alone at a window seat, read his phone the entire time. Dan stayed in the car. At eleven-forty Travis walked back. The time, the route, the restaurant.

In the afternoon he drove the perimeter of the development site on Music Row. The block was mostly vacant lots and three old buildings in a row, the farthest of which had a faded sign Dan couldn't read from the street. A construction fence ran along one side with a banner: HARMONY RIDGE

DEVELOPMENT — A PREMIER MIXED-USE COMMUNITY. Below that, in smaller text, the name of the development company — Carsten Properties — and a phone number. A black Cadillac Escalade was parked inside the fence at the south corner, looking expensive and out of place next to the mud and gravel.

Dan drove past without slowing. He didn't write anything down. He didn't need to.

He came back to city hall at four-thirty and waited. Travis left at five-fifteen, messenger bag over the same shoulder, same stride. He got in the Tacoma and drove east. Dan followed at a comfortable distance, three cars back, and watched Travis pull into the driveway of a bungalow on Fatherland Street with a deep porch and a bicycle locked to the railing.

Dan drove past and circled the block once. Quiet street, older houses, a few renovations in progress. The sight lines were clean, the neighboring properties set back, an alley running behind the house. He drove home.

At the apartment he made dinner — pasta, jarred sauce, a beer from the fridge — and ate standing at the counter, looking at the corkboard through the open door of the spare bedroom. Travis Boone's face looked back at him, square-jawed and direct, caught mid-gesture in a conversation Dan couldn't hear.

He washed the dish, dried it, put it away. Turned off the kitchen light and sat down at his desk to write up the day's observations in a notebook he'd burn when the job was done.

Routine, distance, patience. The target had a life that was easy to map and a schedule that repeated. Dan would spend the week confirming the pattern before he started thinking about the evening itself. There was no rush. The job was clean and the preparation was simple, and in two weeks Travis Boone would stop coming out of city hall at five-fifteen, and the gray Tacoma would sit in the driveway on Fatherland Street until someone came to ask why.

Chapter 3 — Patterns

By Thursday Dan had the week mapped — two days of his own watching laid over the broker's pattern summary, and the two agreed. Travis Boone went to city hall by eight, left between five and five-thirty. Lunch out most days — the same taco place, once a Thai restaurant on Fourth. After work he went home to the bungalow on Fatherland. One evening he ran — out the door in shorts and a faded Predators t-shirt, through Shelby Park, back in forty minutes. Another evening a friend came by and they sat on the porch with beers until dark. No bars, no dates, no second stops. The man worked and ate and ran and went to sleep.

On Friday, Dan drove past the development site again. The Escalade was there, same spot at the south corner. This time a man in a gray suit was standing beside it, talking on the phone. Fifties, heavy through the middle, silver hair combed straight back. He held the phone away from his ear and looked at the screen, then put it back and kept talking. Dan was past him in three seconds and didn't slow down. Same Escalade he'd seen at the site on Wednesday, but now he had a face to go with it.

Sunday morning Travis drove south on I-24. Dan followed from a quarter mile back, staying in the right lane. The Tacoma took the Murfreesboro exit and turned onto a two-lane road lined with fences and hay rolls. After a few miles it pulled into the driveway of a ranch house set back from the road — white siding, green roof, a vegetable garden along one side with tomato cages still up from last season. A Ford F-150 sat in the carport, old enough to be paid off.

Travis hadn't fully stopped the truck before a woman came out the front door carrying a foil-wrapped package the size of a shoebox. She was short, round, and moved with the speed of someone who'd been watching for him from the window. She handed the package through the driver's side before Travis could get out, said something, and swatted his arm when he said something back. Then she stood aside while he climbed down and they walked toward the house together, her hand on his back for a moment.

A man appeared on the porch. Tall like Travis, but thinner, slower. He wore a plaid shirt tucked into jeans and held a coffee mug in one hand. He didn't

come down the steps. Travis said something to him from the walkway and the man nodded once and went back inside, leaving the door open behind him.

Dan was parked up the street under a hackberry tree, engine off, window down. The air smelled like cut grass and warm dirt. A dog barked somewhere behind the house. He could hear birds and, distantly, a lawn mower. He waited.

An hour and twenty minutes. Travis came out carrying a different container — a Tupperware, bigger than the foil package, probably enough food for three or four days. His mother followed him to the truck and stood in the driveway while he backed out. She was still standing there when he turned onto the road.

Dan let him go. He already knew where Travis was heading.

He sat for another minute under the hackberry, looking at the ranch house. The father had come back out onto the porch with his coffee. He watched the road where the Tacoma had been, then went back inside.

Dan started the Volvo and drove back to Nashville.

The next week, on Wednesday, Travis didn't show up at city hall.

Dan had a department meeting that morning and didn't get to his usual spot until after ten. No Tacoma in the employee lot. He drove to Fatherland Street. The truck was in the driveway. Curtains drawn. Dan circled the block and parked on the next street over where he could see the side of the house through a gap between two renovated bungalows.

At one-forty in the afternoon Travis came out. He was wearing a suit — the first time Dan had seen him in anything other than chinos and a button-down. Dark jacket, no tie, slacks that looked new. He got in the Tacoma and drove west, not toward city hall.

Dan followed. Travis drove to a law office on Church Street — a two-story limestone building with brass lettering on the door. He parked on the street

and went inside. Dan found a spot across the intersection and waited. Travis was in there an hour and ten minutes. When he came out he stood on the sidewalk for a moment, looking at nothing, his hands in his pockets. Then he got in the truck and drove home.

Thursday, Dan had obligations he couldn't keep skipping — the eleven o'clock lecture, office hours, a stack of response papers he'd promised back. He didn't get to city hall until Friday afternoon, and when he drove past at four-thirty the Tacoma wasn't in the employee lot. He swung by Fatherland Street on the way home. The truck was in the driveway, the curtains were drawn, and the house had the stillness of a place nobody had left all day.

The pattern hadn't cracked. It had collapsed. Dan didn't know why and didn't particularly care — people had problems: money, health, family, legal. His concern was scheduling. A target with a routine could be planned around. A man holed up in his house with a lawyer's number in his phone could not. Whatever had knocked Travis Boone out of his orbit, Dan would have to wait for him to settle into a new one.

Back at the apartment, he sat at his desk in the spare bedroom, updating his notebook. A week and a half of entries, and the last two days thinned into question marks. He'd give it the weekend and see what Monday looked like. He closed the notebook and went to make dinner.

Chapter 4 — The News

The prepaid rang on a Saturday morning. Dan was at the kitchen table reading a monograph on Cold War espionage in Vienna, a cup of coffee going cold beside it. He picked up.

“Morning,” the broker said. “You been watching the news down there?”

“I don’t watch the news.”

“Maybe you should. Your guy’s been busy.”

Dan set the monograph down. “My guy’s been off. Missed work Wednesday, spent an hour at a law office on Church Street, and by Friday he’d gone to ground at home. I figured personal trouble.”

“That’s one way to put it.” The broker sounded like he was smiling. “A land broker named Garrett Kinsey got shot Tuesday night. Two rounds, parking lot behind a strip mall on Dickerson Pike. Your man Boone was arrested Thursday morning.”

Dan looked at the coffee. “Arrested for the shooting?”

“Charged with murder. He’s out on bond — parents put up the house, from what I hear. Trial’s pending.”

“And this is the land broker connected to the development.”

“The very one. Kinsey was the point man between the developers and the city. He and Boone had been going at it publicly for months — council meetings, emails, the whole paper trail. Prosecution says Boone finally snapped.”

“Did he?”

“Does it matter? The client’s thrilled. If the state convicts him, the problem’s solved and nobody owes you a nickel past the retainer. If he walks, you finish the job.”

“So I’m on hold.”

“You’re on hold. Paid hold, I should point out. You’ve got the retainer, nobody’s asking for it back, and you don’t have to do a thing until this plays out.”

“How long?”

“Trial’s set for five weeks out. Prosecution’s pushing — they think they’ve got a clean case and the judge agreed to an early date. Defense didn’t fight it.”

“Defense wants it over.”

“Sounds like Boone’s the type.”

Dan picked up the coffee, took a sip, set it back down. It was cold. “The client — they know anything about this Kinsey situation they’re not sharing?”

A pause. Shorter than the one in their first call, but Dan caught it. “The client’s a real estate outfit that hired us to solve a personnel problem. What happened to their land broker is their business, not ours.”

“I’m just asking if there’s overlap I should know about.”

“There’s no overlap you should know about.”

Dan let that sit. The broker’s answer was careful, which was the broker’s answer.

“All right,” Dan said. “I’ll keep loose tabs on Boone. If he walks, I’ll need a week to reacquire his pattern. It’s going to be different post-trial.”

“Understood. I’ll check in when the verdict comes down. Or before, if anything changes.”

“Fine.”

“Enjoy the time off. Not many people in your line get a paid vacation.”

The line went dead.

Dan rinsed the coffee cup, poured a fresh one, and stood at the window. The cellist’s Subaru was parked across the street again. A jogger went past with a Labrador on a short leash.

Garrett Kinsey. The name meant nothing to him. A land broker who’d gotten shot in a parking lot — it happened in Nashville more often than the

tourism board liked to advertise. The police had a suspect, the suspect was out on bond, and the legal system would do whatever the legal system did. None of it was Dan's concern.

What was his concern: Travis Boone was now unkillable for the foreseeable future. A murder defendant on bond, lawyered up, under the attention of the Davidson County DA's office and probably half the local press. If Dan touched him now, the investigation would pull in everyone who'd ever looked sideways at Boone, including the development outfit that hired the contract. The job was frozen.

Dan didn't mind. The retainer was in his account. His classes were covered. The weather was warm and Nashville was easy.

He kept loose tabs over the following weeks. Drove past Fatherland Street every few days — the Tacoma was always there now. Travis's life had contracted to three points: the bungalow, the law office on Church Street, and the road to Murfreesboro on Sundays. No city hall. No taco place. No evening runs. He moved between the three points and stayed inside the rest of the time. Dan saw him once, coming out of the lawyer's office in the same dark suit, and the man looked like he'd dropped ten pounds.

The trial date approached. The local news ran a piece Dan didn't watch but heard about from Sheila at the department — something about a city official and a shooting, she couldn't remember the details. Dan nodded and said it sounded terrible.

The jury summons was still on his kitchen counter, under the Tennessee State Museum magnet. Reporting date: Monday. He'd deal with it Monday. Spend a day in a room full of strangers, answer some questions, get sent home. Maybe sit through a day of testimony about a fender bender or a property dispute. Then back to his regular life, such as it was, waiting for a trial he wasn't part of to tell him whether he still had a job to do.

He set his alarm for six-thirty and went to bed.

Chapter 5 — Juror Nine

The Davidson County Criminal Justice Center was a block of limestone and glass on Second Avenue, the kind of building that looked like it had been designed by committee and approved by nobody in particular. Dan parked the Volvo in a garage two blocks north and walked. The morning was already warm, the sidewalks busy with people headed to offices and coffee shops. Dan walked with them, unremarkable, a paperback in his jacket pocket.

The security line moved slowly. Two metal detectors, four deputies, a conveyor belt for bags. Dan emptied his pockets into a plastic tray — wallet, keys, university phone — and walked through clean. On the other side he picked up his things and scanned the lobby without turning his head. Two exits besides the front entrance. A stairwell to the left, elevators to the right. Security cameras at the corners and above the elevator bank. A deputy at a desk directing foot traffic.

He followed the signs to the jury assembly room on the second floor.

It was a large room with fluorescent lights and rows of padded chairs, most of them occupied. A hundred and fifty people, maybe more, sitting with the collective enthusiasm of a waiting room at the DMV. A table near the door had a coffee urn, a sleeve of paper cups, and a basket of granola bars that looked like they'd been there since the previous week.

Dan took a seat in the back row, opened his paperback — a used copy of John Lewis Gaddis on the Cold War — and waited.

A woman in the row ahead of him turned to the man beside her. “How long does this usually take?”

“My brother did it last year. Said he was here till three and never got called.”

“Three? I’ve got a dentist appointment at two.”

“You can tell them that. They’ve got a form.”

“What form?”

“I don’t know. A hardship form or something. You go up to the desk.”

A clerk at the front of the room was trying to get everyone's attention. She was small, mid-forties, with reading glasses on a chain and a voice that had been doing this long enough to stop expecting cooperation.

"If everyone could take a seat and put their phones away, we'll get started with orientation."

Nobody put their phones away.

"I need everyone's attention, please. This will take about ten minutes and then we'll begin calling groups."

A man three rows up raised his hand. "Can I ask a question?"

"After the orientation, sir."

"I just need to know if there's parking validation."

"There is not."

"So we're paying to park all day?"

"You'll receive a check for forty dollars at the end of your service. If everyone could—"

"Forty dollars doesn't cover parking."

The clerk smiled. She'd had this conversation before. "The forty dollars is your juror compensation. Parking is not included. Now, if everyone could —"

"My boss is going to dock me for today. Is there a letter or something I can bring back?"

"We'll cover that in the orientation, sir. Which I am trying to start."

Dan turned a page in his book. Around him, people shifted in their chairs, checked their phones under their laps, whispered to their neighbors. A young woman in scrubs was filling out what looked like the hardship form. An older man in a blazer had fallen asleep with his arms crossed.

The clerk ran through the orientation — how the day would work, when breaks happened, what to do if called, what to do if not called. She explained the difference between civil and criminal trials. She explained that jury

service was a cornerstone of American democracy. She said this in the same tone she'd used to explain the parking situation.

At ten-fifteen the first group was called. Thirty names read from a list. Dan's wasn't among them. They filed out. The room got quieter.

At eleven, a second group. Dan heard his name — "Mercer, Daniel" — and stood. He pocketed the Gaddis book and followed the line of jurors down a hallway and through a set of double doors into a courtroom.

It was smaller than he expected. Wood-paneled walls, a dropped ceiling with recessed lights, the state seal behind the judge's bench. The gallery had four rows of seating, mostly empty. A bailiff stood near the side door with his hands clasped behind his back.

Dan took it in without pausing. Two exits plus the door they'd come through. The judge's bench was elevated, the witness stand to its right. The jury box ran along the left wall, closest to the witness stand. Two tables faced the bench — prosecution on the left, nearest the jury, defense on the right.

The prosecution table had a man in a navy suit, early forties, with a legal pad and two file boxes. He sat like he'd been there before and expected to be back.

The defense table had a woman, maybe fifty, in a charcoal jacket with her brown hair pulled back, gray showing at the part. She was narrow through the shoulders, sharp-featured, and she was writing something, her eyes on the page. A young man beside her — the intern, probably — was sorting documents into folders. His tie was slightly crooked.

Between the defense attorney and the intern, facing forward with his hands flat on the table, sat Travis Boone.

Dan's step didn't change. He walked to the jury box with the rest of the group — a history professor in khakis and a button-down, graying at the temples, unremarkable among the civilians filing in around him — and took the seat he was directed to. Ninth chair from the left.

Travis was thinner than the last time Dan had seen him. The suit was the same dark one from the law office visits, but it hung differently now —

loose through the shoulders, the collar gapping at the neck. His hair was shorter than it had been during surveillance, freshly cut, which made his face look harder and more angular. He sat very still, looking straight ahead, his jaw tight.

Dan settled into the chair and rested his hands on his knees. He looked at the judge's bench, then at the prosecution table, then — briefly, the way you'd glance at anyone — at the defense table.

Travis Boone looked back at him for a half second — a defendant scanning every face in the room, checking for something he won't find. Then his eyes moved on.

Dan had spent the better part of two weeks learning this man — the long stride, the gray Tacoma, the Sunday drive to Murfreesboro — all of it pointed at a single evening that never came. He knew Travis Boone's face better than most of the people who loved him did, studied from across a street and through a windshield, and Travis had just looked straight into it and found nothing to catch on. The face he'd mapped for killing was the face he'd now sit across from for a week, one of twelve deciding whether it walked back out into the world. He set the thought down. There was nowhere to put it yet.

Dan opened the Gaddis book to his page and held it on his lap. The judge hadn't entered yet. Around him, the other potential jurors were settling in, coughing, whispering, adjusting their clothes.

He sat in the ninth chair and waited for whatever came next.

Chapter 6 — Voir Dire

The judge entered through a side door and everyone stood, which took longer than it should have because half the potential jurors didn't know they were supposed to. The bailiff said "All rise" and then said it again, louder, and a woman in the second row of the gallery whispered to her neighbor, "Do we stand too?" and her neighbor said, "I think so," and they both stood, though neither of them was a juror.

The judge was mid-sixties, balding, with wire-rimmed glasses and the posture of a man who'd been sitting in that chair long enough that the chair had shaped him. He thanked them for their service. He said the jury system was the cornerstone of American democracy. He said it in the same flat tone the clerk downstairs had used — a sentence he'd stopped hearing himself say sometime during the previous administration.

He explained voir dire. The attorneys would ask questions. The questions were not a test. There were no wrong answers. He said this last part with a slight pause that suggested long experience to the contrary.

The prosecutor went first. He stood, buttoned his jacket, and introduced himself — his name was something Dan didn't bother to retain because it would be repeated a hundred times before the trial was over. He started with the front row of the jury box, working left to right, asking each person whether they could be fair and impartial.

The first woman said yes.

The second woman said yes but wanted to know how long the trial would last because she was supposed to fly to Tucson on Thursday for her daughter's baby shower.

"That's a question for His Honor," the prosecutor said.

The judge looked at the woman. "How far along is your daughter?"

"Eight months."

"Then she'll still be pregnant next week. We'll discuss scheduling after voir dire, ma'am."

The third person, a man in a tracksuit, said he couldn't be impartial because he'd been arrested once and the whole thing was rigged.

"What were you arrested for?" the prosecutor asked.

"DUI. But I wasn't drunk."

"Were you driving?"

"That's not the point."

The judge leaned forward. "It might be the point, actually."

The prosecutor moved on. A retired teacher said she'd be happy to serve. A young man in a UPS uniform said he couldn't miss work. An older woman asked whether the trial involved anything upsetting because she had a heart condition, and when the prosecutor said it was a murder case she said, "Oh, I watch those shows all the time. I'll be fine."

A man in the second row raised his hand without being called on. "Can I ask — is this the one that was on the news? The city guy?"

The judge said, "Sir, we'll get to questions about pretrial publicity. For now —"

"Because my wife follows that. She has opinions."

"Your wife isn't on the jury, sir."

"No, but she'll ask me about it."

The judge looked at the prosecutor. The prosecutor looked at his legal pad. Nobody said anything for a moment.

A woman said she didn't believe in judging people, which produced a brief silence in which the judge, the prosecutor, and the defense attorney all looked at the same spot on the wall.

"Thank you, ma'am," the judge said. "You're excused."

She gathered her purse and left, and the judge watched her go with an expression that was not quite a smile but adjacent to one.

The defense attorney took her turn. She stood without buttoning anything, a legal pad in one hand, and she didn't introduce herself — she'd apparently

decided they'd heard enough introductions. She was direct. Her voice was lower than the prosecutor's and she used fewer words per question, which made each one land harder.

She asked whether anyone had a close relationship with law enforcement. Two hands went up. She asked follow-ups — what kind of relationship, could they set that aside. One said yes and seemed to mean it. The other said yes and clearly didn't. The defense attorney made a note and moved on.

She asked whether anyone believed that being charged with a crime was itself evidence of guilt. Nobody raised a hand, but a man in a polo shirt tucked into khakis, phone holster clipped to his belt, shifted in his seat and said, "Well, I mean, they don't just arrest people for no reason."

The defense attorney looked at him. "You don't think so?"

"I'm saying there's a process. They investigate, they get evidence, they make an arrest. That's how it works."

"And if the process made a mistake?"

"Then the trial sorts it out. That's what we're here for."

He said it with complete confidence, nodding once as if he'd settled the matter. The defense attorney wrote something on her pad. The prosecutor, to his credit, kept his face neutral.

"Your name, sir?"

"Gary Burris."

"Mr. Burris, the defendant is presumed innocent. You understand that?"

"Sure. Innocent until proven guilty."

"And if the prosecution doesn't prove guilt beyond a reasonable doubt, your vote would be not guilty. Regardless of what you personally think happened."

Gary considered this. "Right. But if they arrested him, they probably have a pretty good reason."

The defense attorney looked at the judge. The judge looked at Gary Burris. Thirty years on the bench had given him a precise understanding of the gap between what a juror said and what a juror could be excused for saying. Gary hadn't crossed the line. He'd walked up to it, looked at it, and wandered away in the wrong direction, but he hadn't crossed it.

"Thank you, Mr. Burris," the defense attorney said.

The questioning continued through the morning. The judge called a lunch recess at twelve-thirty, and the afternoon session picked up where the morning had left off — the same questions finding the same answers in different vocabularies. The judge excused four jurors for cause. The attorneys spent their peremptory challenges at the sidebar in ones and twos, and the pool thinned with each conference. Dan had watched the pattern form: most people, when asked whether they could be impartial, said yes. Most people, when asked whether they understood reasonable doubt, said they did. The answers varied in confidence and vocabulary but not in substance. A consensus had settled over the room like a shared script nobody remembered receiving.

When the prosecutor reached Dan, the questions were familiar.

"Mr. Mercer, what do you do for a living?"

"I'm a history professor."

"Any prior experience with the legal system? Served on a jury, been a witness, anything like that?"

"No."

"Do you believe you can evaluate the evidence in this case fairly and impartially?"

"I do."

The prosecutor nodded. He'd heard this answer thirty times today and Dan had given him no reason to hear it differently now.

The defense attorney stood. She looked at her legal pad, then at Dan.

“Mr. Mercer, let me ask you something. If the prosecution presents evidence that looks strong — compelling, even — but you have a reasonable doubt about whether it proves what they say it proves, could you vote to acquit?”

“Yes.”

“Even if other jurors disagreed with you?”

“If I had a genuine doubt, yes.”

She paused. She was choosing her next words carefully, and Dan could see her calculating how close to the line the judge would let her walk.

“Do you believe,” she said, “that there are situations where following the law — truly following it — might require you to look past what seems obvious on the surface?”

Dan let a beat pass. Not long enough to seem rehearsed, not short enough to seem reflexive.

“I think that’s what reasonable doubt is for,” he said. “If the standard were just ‘does it seem like he did it,’ we wouldn’t need twelve people in a room.”

The defense attorney looked at him for a moment longer than she had at anyone else. Then she nodded and sat down.

At the defense table, Travis Boone was watching. He’d been watching all morning — not the attorneys, not the judge, but the jurors. His hands were still flat on the table the way they’d been when Dan first saw him, and he held himself very still, following each answer with the focus of a man trying to read his own future in the responses of strangers. He didn’t react to good answers or bad ones. He just absorbed them.

Dan noticed, and turned back to the front of the room.

The judge read the final list at four-forty, both sides’ challenges long spent. Twelve jurors and two alternates. He read the names in order of seating — last names only, flat and procedural — a roster, nothing more.

Dan heard “Mercer” ninth.

Somewhere between the prosecutor's first question and the defense attorney's last, he'd decided he was better off in the room than out of it. It wasn't a complicated thought. It was a professional one: he'd assessed the options and chosen the one that left him the most control.

He put the Gaddis book in his jacket pocket, leaned back in the ninth chair, and waited for the judge to tell them when to come back.

Chapter 7 — Opening Statements

The jury filed in at nine the next morning. Dan took his seat — ninth chair, left side of the box — and set the Gaddis book on his knee. The courtroom was the same room from yesterday but it felt different now, tighter, the empty gallery rows filled with a handful of spectators and two reporters with notebooks. The bailiff stood by the side door. The court reporter was already seated, fingers resting on her machine.

Travis Boone was at the defense table in the same dark suit. It fit him worse than it had the day before, which wasn't possible — a suit doesn't change overnight — but that was the impression. He sat with his palms down on the table, shoulders square, looking straight ahead. The defense attorney beside him was reviewing a legal pad. The intern sorted folders.

Travis glanced over his shoulder toward the back row of the gallery. A short, round woman and a tall man in a plaid shirt sat side by side, the woman leaning forward with her hands clasped, the man upright and still beside her. They both looked like they'd driven a long way on not enough sleep. Travis turned back to the front. He didn't nod or wave — just looked, and then didn't.

Dan knew them. The woman from the Murfreesboro driveway, who'd handed a foil package through a truck window before her son could climb out. The man on the porch with the coffee mug, who hadn't come down the steps. Dan had watched them for four minutes on a Sunday morning and logged them as *family, low relevance*. Now they sat in the back row, watching the man he'd been hired to kill go on trial, and Dan sat twelve feet from their son with the power to send him to prison. He looked at the empty bench and kept his face where it was.

The judge entered. Everyone stood. He took his place on the bench, put on his reading glasses, and looked out over the room with the flat recognition of a commute he'd driven ten thousand times.

"Mr. Caldwell," the judge said. "Opening statement."

The prosecutor stood, buttoned his jacket, and stepped to the front of the jury box. He was comfortable up there. He held a single notecard in his left hand and didn't look at it.

“Ladies and gentlemen,” he said. “On the night of April fourteenth, a man named Garrett Kinsey drove to a strip mall on Dickerson Pike. He parked in the rear lot, behind the building, near a dumpster and a loading dock. Sometime between eight-thirty and ten that evening, someone walked up to Garrett Kinsey and shot him twice. Both rounds struck him in the chest. He died in that parking lot.”

Caldwell stopped there. Then he walked them through it.

Kinsey was a land broker. He worked as the point man between a Nashville development company and the city on a project along Music Row — mixed-use, condos, retail, another one going up on every block in Nashville now. Travis Boone was a planning commissioner assigned to review that project. He and Kinsey had clashed publicly — council meetings, emails, a confrontation at a planning session that three witnesses would describe. Their disagreements were documented, personal, and escalating.

Travis Boone owned a nine-millimeter handgun, bought legally and in his name. He visited the Hendersonville Firearms Range on four occasions in the three months before the killing. Ballistics testing matched rounds recovered from Kinsey’s body to Boone’s weapon.

Caldwell said all of this the way you’d read a report — clear, orderly, unhurried. He wasn’t selling. He was laying bricks.

“The evidence will show,” he said, “that Travis Boone had motive, means, and opportunity. That he had a documented history of conflict with the victim. That his weapon fired the rounds that killed Garrett Kinsey. And that he cannot account for his whereabouts during the window in which the murder occurred.”

He paused. Then he turned slightly toward the defense table.

“The defendant has also demonstrated a pattern of physical aggression. Mr. Boone’s nose has been broken — visibly broken, set off-center — an injury consistent with—”

The defense attorney was on her feet. “Objection, Your Honor.”

The judge looked at Caldwell over his glasses. “Where are we going with this, counselor?”

“The state intends to establish a pattern of—”

“When did the injury occur?”

Caldwell paused. “The specific date hasn’t been—”

“How did it occur?”

“Your Honor, the visible evidence of a prior—”

“Mr. Caldwell. If you can tell me when Mr. Boone’s nose was broken and connect it to a documented incident, I’ll hear it. Otherwise, move along.”

Caldwell moved along.

Dan looked at Travis. The nose was there, plain enough now that someone had pointed at it — set slightly off-center, a bump along the bridge where the cartilage had healed crooked. Old. Years old. A caught elbow in a pickup game, maybe, or a bar conversation that went sideways. Not a fighter’s nose. Just a nose that had been broken once.

In the second row of the jury box, Gary Burris wrote something on his notepad. Two seats down from Gary, another man did the same — tall, straight-backed, with close-cropped white hair and the bearing of someone who’d spent decades in a uniform. Dan hadn’t heard much from him during voir dire. He held his pen like he was filling out a report.

Two jurors. Two notes. Both of them writing down the thing the judge had just told the prosecutor to drop.

Caldwell finished his opening without the nose. He thanked the jury for their time and attention and sat down. The notecard went back in his jacket pocket. He hadn’t looked at it once.

The judge nodded toward the defense table. “Ms. Barr.”

The defense attorney stood. She didn’t move to the front of the jury box like Caldwell had. She stayed behind her table, one hand resting on the legal pad she didn’t pick up.

“Mr. Caldwell just told you a story,” she said. “It’s a well-organized story. It has a victim, a suspect, a weapon, and a motive. Everything in its place.” She paused. “What it doesn’t have is anyone who saw my client at that

parking lot on the night of April fourteenth. No eyewitness. No surveillance footage. No phone records placing him at the scene.”

She didn’t fill the silence.

“You’re going to hear about arguments between Travis Boone and Garrett Kinsey. Professional disagreements about a development project — the kind of disagreements that happen in city government every week. People argue about zoning, about permits, about land use. They send sharp emails. They raise their voices at public meetings. That is not motive for murder. That is Tuesday.”

A small sound from somewhere in the jury box — not quite a laugh, just an exhale. The defense attorney didn’t react to it.

“You’re going to hear about a ballistics match. You should listen carefully to that testimony when it comes, because a match is not as simple as Mr. Caldwell made it sound. You’re going to hear about Mr. Boone’s visits to a shooting range — legal visits, to a legal range, with a legally owned firearm. And you’re going to hear a timeline with a gap in it that the prosecution cannot close.”

She looked at the jury. Not scanning, not working the room — just looking, until she was sure they were listening.

“The standard is not ‘probably.’ The standard is not ‘it looks like he did it.’ The standard is beyond a reasonable doubt. I’d ask you to hold the prosecution to that standard. Thank you.”

She sat down. The whole thing had taken less than three minutes.

The judge called a fifteen-minute recess. Dan stood with the rest of the jury and filed into the hallway. He stood by a window that looked out over Second Avenue, his hands in his pockets, until the bailiff called them back in.

The judge told them testimony would begin the following morning at nine. He reminded them not to discuss the case, not to read news coverage, and not to form opinions until all evidence had been presented. He said this with the weary precision of a man who knew at least three of them would check their phones in the elevator.

Dan walked to the garage two blocks north. The Volvo started on the first try. He sat for a moment before pulling out. The prepaid was at home in the kitchen drawer — it couldn't come through courthouse security — and whatever was on it would keep until evening.

He pulled into traffic on Second Avenue and drove toward Hillsboro Village, the prosecution's opening running through his head in the flat, orderly way Caldwell had delivered it.

Two shots. Parking lot. Rear of the building.

Dan had been in a lot of parking lots.

Two rounds in the chest from close range, both hitting center mass — that was either very lucky or very practiced. The prosecution was selling heat-of-the-moment. A man pushed past his limit. But two clean shots to the chest wasn't heat-of-the-moment. It wasn't an argument that went wrong. It was a decision, made and executed.

He turned onto Twenty-First Avenue and let the thought sit where it was. The jury room was where that thought lived, if it lived anywhere. Not here. Not yet.

Chapter 8 — The Evening

He didn't take the direct route home.

Music Row was ten minutes out of the way, maybe less. Dan turned south off Broadway and drove past the bars and the bachelorette parties and the pedal taverns full of women in matching t-shirts, and then the noise dropped away and the street narrowed and the buildings got older.

The Harmony Ridge Development site sat behind a chain-link fence topped with green privacy screen. The banner was still there — HARMONY RIDGE DEVELOPMENT: A PREMIER MIXED-USE COMMUNITY — faded now, the corners curling. Behind it, vacant lots and three old buildings, one with a sign too weathered to read from the car. No construction equipment. No workers. Whatever Carsten Properties had planned for this stretch of Music Row, it was waiting on something.

Dan slowed but didn't stop. The last time he'd been here he'd been watching Travis Boone's routine, mapping the man's life the way you map any target — schedules, patterns, vulnerabilities. He'd seen the Escalade parked at the curb, the heavy man in the gray suit talking on his phone. Background. Furniture. He'd absorbed it and moved on because none of it was relevant to the job.

Now a prosecutor named Caldwell had told him a man died over this piece of ground.

He kept driving.

Dickerson Pike was farther out of the way. He took it anyway, heading northeast through parts of Nashville that didn't make the tourism brochures — pawn shops, auto lots, a check-cashing place with bars on the windows. The strip mall was on the right, set back from the road. A dry cleaner, a phone repair shop, a tax preparer with a CLOSED sign in the window. Dan pulled into the lot and drove around to the back.

The parking lot was small. A dumpster against the rear wall, a loading dock with a rusted roll-up door, two light poles — one working, one not. The asphalt was cracked and oil-stained. A wire fence separated the lot from an

alley that ran behind a row of houses. Beyond the fence, a dog barked twice and stopped.

Dan sat in the Volvo with the engine running. He didn't get out. He didn't need to.

One way in by car, same way out. A pedestrian could come through the alley and over the fence, but that meant premeditation, not impulse. The working light pole was on the east side, which meant the west side — near the dumpster, near where you'd park if you were meeting someone behind a building after dark — was in shadow. Two shots to the chest from close range. The shooter had walked up, not fired from a distance.

Caldwell's version was a man in a rage. A confrontation that went too far. But a man in a rage doesn't pick the dark side of a parking lot behind a strip mall on Dickerson Pike. A man in a rage does it in a driveway, or an office, or a bar parking lot after too many drinks. This was chosen. The location was chosen.

Dan put the car in reverse and pulled back onto Dickerson Pike. It was just a parking lot. He'd seen hundreds.

The apartment was cool and still. Third floor, windows open, the sound of traffic on Twenty-First Avenue softened by distance and the old trees along the street. Dan hung his jacket on the hook by the door and stood in the kitchen for a moment, deciding what to eat.

He made pasta — olive oil, garlic, whatever was in the vegetable drawer. A handful of spinach that was a day from going bad. He ate standing at the counter, looking out the window at the rooftops and the fading light.

After he washed the plate and the pan and set them in the rack, he noticed the dissertation on the counter near the toaster. He'd ordered it through interlibrary loan weeks ago — African American music venues in the mid-South, 1945 to 1968. A doctoral thesis from Memphis, photocopied and spiral-bound, with a coffee ring on the cover that predated Dan's ownership. He'd requested it for his own research, before the Boone contract,

before any of this. He picked it up, opened it to where he'd left a pencil as a bookmark, read half a page about a recording studio on Jefferson Street, and set it back down.

He called his sister using the university phone. She picked up on the third ring.

"Hey," he said. "How's the new job?"

She told him. It was fine — her boss was fine, the commute was fine, she was still figuring out where to park. She asked how he was.

"Jury duty," he said. "Murder trial."

"God. How long?"

"They haven't said. Could be a week, could be two."

"Are you eating?"

"Just did."

"Real food?"

"Pasta."

She said that didn't count, and he said it counted, and she said she'd call him Sunday. He said that was fine.

He put the phone down and stood in the kitchen. The apartment was quiet — not empty quiet, but the settled kind, chosen and maintained. The spare bedroom door was closed. It was always closed.

He took the prepaid out of the drawer. One message, received at eight-fourteen that morning.

How's Nashville treating you?

He typed a reply.

Quiet. Waiting like everyone else.

He put the phone back in the drawer, next to the coffee filters, and pushed it shut.

In bed he read thirty pages of the Gaddis and turned off the lamp. The streetlight on Twenty-First came through the window, the same pale stripe across the ceiling it made every night. Testimony started at nine. He closed his eyes and let it go.

Chapter 9 — The Defendant

Travis hung the suit on the back of the bedroom door and stood there in his undershirt and boxers, looking at it. The jacket was too wide through the shoulders now. His mother had noticed — she'd said something about taking it to the tailor on Gallatin Road, the one who did his father's church pants, and Travis had said sure, fine, knowing he wouldn't do it. The suit was the least of it.

He pulled on jeans and a t-shirt — the faded Predators shirt he'd had since college — and walked barefoot into the kitchen. The bungalow was quiet. It had always been quiet, living alone, but this was different. Before, the silence had been his. He'd chosen it — the porch, the street, the neighborhood where people waved but didn't linger. Now it felt like something left behind after everything else had been taken.

He opened the refrigerator, looked at what was inside, and closed it.

The bicycle was still locked to the porch railing. He could see it through the front window — the same spot it had been in since before the arrest. He used to ride it to Shelby Park on weekends, or down to the coffee shop on Woodland. He hadn't unlocked it in five weeks. Hadn't run, either. The routines that used to hold his days together had fallen away one by one, replaced by the law office and the courtroom and the long drive to Murfreesboro on Sundays because his parents needed to see him and he needed to let them.

He stood at the kitchen counter and ate a bowl of cereal because it was there and didn't require thought.

Today a man named Caldwell had stood fifteen feet from him and told a room full of strangers that Travis Boone had shot Garrett Kinsey twice in the chest in a parking lot on Dickerson Pike. He'd said it calmly, like he was reading a weather report. Documented disputes. Escalating conflict. A nine-millimeter handgun, purchased in the defendant's name. Ballistics match.

Travis had sat through it with his hands pressed to the table and his jaw locked — still, neutral, no reactions, just like Barr had drilled into him. He'd wanted to stand up and say *that is not what happened, someone took my gun, someone broke into my house and stole it while I was visiting my parents in*

Murfreesboro, and you would know that if you'd bothered to look. But Barr had been clear about what he could and couldn't do at the defense table, and standing up to shout at the prosecutor was on the wrong list.

Then Caldwell had brought up his nose. His broken nose, which he'd gotten in a pickup basketball game when he was twenty-six — an elbow from a guy named Marcus who'd apologized immediately and bought him a beer afterward — and Caldwell had tried to turn it into evidence that Travis was violent. The judge shut it down. But Travis had seen two jurors write something on their notepads, and he knew what they'd written.

He rinsed the cereal bowl and left it in the sink.

The back door had a new deadbolt. Brushed steel, heavy, the kind you couldn't pick with a credit card and a screwdriver. The locksmith — a heavysset man from Inglewood who'd come on a Thursday afternoon, three weeks after the arrest — had looked at the old lock on the back door and shaken his head.

"This?" he'd said, holding the old knob set. "I could open this with a tension wrench and a bobby pin. Takes about forty seconds."

He'd replaced every lock in the house. Front door, back door, the side window that didn't latch right, the sliding door to the patio. New hardware, new keys, new deadbolts. Travis had written him a check for eleven hundred dollars and watched him leave, then stood at the back door and looked at the alley.

He was standing there again now.

The alley ran behind the row of houses on Fatherland Street. Gravel and packed dirt, wide enough for a car, lined with fences and garbage cans and the occasional abandoned furniture. Anyone could walk down it at night without being seen. From the alley to the back door was twelve steps — Travis had counted. Through the old lock in forty seconds, and then they were inside.

The gun had been in the nightstand. A nine-millimeter he'd bought four years ago after a string of break-ins on the next block. He'd taken it to the range a few times — the Hendersonville place, because it was quiet and the staff left you alone — and then mostly left it in the drawer. It wasn't something he thought about. It was just there, like a fire extinguisher nobody thinks about. Until the Wednesday morning two detectives knocked on his door. Garrett Kinsey was dead, and everyone at the commission knew what the two of them thought of each other. They asked, politely, where he'd been the night before. Travis called in sick, then called a lawyer. The next morning one of them came back and told him ballistics had matched his weapon to two rounds pulled from Garrett Kinsey's body, and Travis opened the nightstand and the gun was gone.

He hadn't reported it missing because he hadn't known it was missing.

That was the part that kept him up at night. Not the arrest, not the trial, not even the prosecutor's calm recitation of the worst version of his life. The fact that someone had been in his house. Had walked through these rooms while he was in Murfreesboro eating his mother's pot roast. Had opened his nightstand, taken his gun, and walked back out through the alley.

Someone who knew he went to Murfreesboro on Sundays.

Travis turned from the back door and walked into the living room. He'd been over this a hundred times. The Carsten Properties people — the ones behind Harmony Ridge, the ones who'd sent Kinsey to lean on the planning commission. He'd dealt with them for months. Meetings, emails, phone calls. They wanted the Music Row site rezoned for high-density residential. Travis had reviewed the documents, done his job, and found what they didn't want anyone to find — the old recording studio, the history buried under their bulldozer plans. He'd flagged it, formally, through the commission. He'd said no.

And then Kinsey was dead and Travis's gun had killed him.

He understood the frame. That part was clear enough — take his gun, use it on Kinsey, let the ballistics and the documented disputes do the rest. What he couldn't understand was why they'd killed Kinsey at all. Kinsey worked for them. He was their broker, their point man, the guy who handled the

money and the paperwork between Carsten Properties and the city. Why murder your own man?

Unless Kinsey had become a problem too.

Travis sat on the couch and stared at the blank television. He turned it over slowly, the way he'd turn over a zoning application, looking for the thing that didn't fit. Kinsey had been the go-between. He knew everything — every deal, every shortcut, every handshake that never made it into the public record. If Kinsey had gotten nervous, or greedy, or if he'd decided to talk to someone he shouldn't have talked to — then the developers had two problems. A broker who knew too much and a commissioner who wouldn't shut up.

Two problems. One dead broker. One stolen gun.

He could almost see it. He couldn't prove any of it.

His mother called at seven-thirty.

"How was the drive home?" Travis asked.

"Your father drove twenty miles under the speed limit the whole way home. I told him there's no prize for being the last car on I-24, and he said he was being careful." She paused. "Are you eating?"

"I ate."

"What did you eat?"

"Cereal."

"Travis."

"It's fine, Mom."

She told him the garden was doing well, that the tomatoes were coming in early this year, and that his father had finally fixed the gate on the carport. She did not mention the opening statements. She did not mention the prosecutor or the jury or the word *murder*. She talked for eight minutes

about tomatoes and parking meters and whether Travis's blue shirt needed pressing, and then she said she loved him and hung up.

He sat with the phone in his hand for a while after.

Barr called at eight-fifteen.

"Tomorrow's going to be harder than today," she said. "The detective takes the stand. Caldwell will walk him through the evidence — the crime scene, the ballistics, the timeline. It'll be detailed and it'll be specific and you need to sit through it without reacting."

"I know."

"I mean it, Travis. No jaw clenching, no head shaking. Look at your hands if you have to."

"I've been doing this."

"You've been doing it well. The nose thing today was a gift — the judge handed us that. Small win, but it matters." She paused. "What's on your mind?"

He told her. The theory he'd been turning over — Kinsey as the developers' weak link, a man who knew too much, killed and used to frame Travis in one move. Two problems, one solution. He'd been thinking about it for weeks, and today, listening to Caldwell lay out the prosecution's case, the shape of it had gotten clearer.

Barr listened without interrupting.

"I can have my investigator pull the corporate filings," she said. "Kinsey's business connections to Carsten Properties — that's public record. If there's a documented relationship, we can use it."

"There is. He was their broker. Everyone at the commission knew that."

"Then we can establish it. But Travis — establishing a connection and proving they killed him are two different thresholds. We need to be careful about what we promise the jury."

"What about the gun? The break-in?"

The pause was brief, but he heard it.

“Without a police report, without forensic evidence of forced entry, without a witness — I can’t prove a break-in. What I can do is get your statement in through Holmes. You told him the gun should be in your nightstand before he’d finished explaining the ballistics match — that’s in his report. I’ll make him say it to the jury tomorrow, and I’ll make him admit that nobody ever looked into it. But that’s the ceiling, Travis. The claim will be in the room. The proof won’t.”

He knew she was right. He’d known it before he asked. But hearing the limits of it said plainly, by the woman his parents had quietly borrowed money to hire, made it heavier.

“Get some sleep,” she said. “Nine o’clock tomorrow. Wear the blue shirt — your mother’s right, it’s better than the white.”

He almost smiled at that.

After he hung up, he sat in the living room and thought about the jury. Twelve faces he’d watched all day, trying to read something in them — doubt, sympathy, anything. Barr had told him a few of them had asked good questions during jury selection, that the panel looked fair, nothing to worry about. She hadn’t said anything negative, which he figured meant there was plenty she wasn’t saying.

He’d noticed one of them during voir dire — ninth seat, a professor of some kind. Lean build, hair cut close and going gray, clean-shaven, lines around his eyes. He looked like he might run in the mornings. The man had given a careful answer about reasonable doubt, something about twelve people in a room. He’d sounded like he meant it. Travis didn’t know if that meant anything. He didn’t know if any of it meant anything. Twelve strangers, and his life was in their hands, and he couldn’t talk to any of them.

He turned off the lights and went to bed. The nightstand was on his left, same as always. The drawer was empty. The new deadbolt on the back door was locked, and the locksmith had promised it would hold, and Travis lay in the dark and listened to the sounds of Fatherland Street through the

open window and tried not to think about what the detective would say tomorrow about the gun that used to be in that drawer.

Chapter 10 — The Detective

Travis was wearing the blue shirt.

Dan noticed it as the jury filed in — a small change from the dark suit and white shirt of the previous days. The blue was better. It softened the jaw, made him look less like he was bracing for impact and more like he'd shown up for work. Somebody had told him to wear it.

The parents were in the gallery, same back row. The mother sat forward in her seat with her purse on her lap. The father was beside her, upright, arms crossed.

Dan set the Gaddis on his knee and waited.

"The state calls Detective Robert Holmes," Caldwell said.

A beat of silence in the jury box. Then Dan smiled. The woman in the third chair covered her mouth with her hand. Gary Burris looked around, confused, as if he'd missed something.

The detective walked to the witness stand and was sworn in. He was mid-fifties, with a thick reddish mustache going gray at the corners and the kind of neck that made his collar look like it was losing an argument. He sat down, adjusted the microphone, and looked at Caldwell with the flat patience of a man who'd done this before and expected to do it again.

"Detective Holmes," Caldwell said, and paused just long enough for the moment to pass. "You were the lead investigator on the Garrett Kinsey homicide. Walk us through what you found at the scene."

Holmes spoke in short declarative sentences — subject, verb, object, full stop. Called to the scene at 7:05 AM on April fifteenth. Victim found in the rear parking lot of a strip mall on Dickerson Pike, behind the building, near the loading dock. Caldwell put a scene diagram on the easel and Holmes walked it: one entrance off the Pike and the same way out, two light poles with only the east one working, a chain-link fence along the back with an alley beyond it. Two gunshot wounds to the chest. Close range — the medical examiner estimated under ten feet. No shell casings recovered. The weapon had not been left at the scene. A nine-millimeter handgun was recovered later that morning from a dumpster in the alley behind the strip

mall, approximately forty yards from the body. The serial number traced to a purchase by Travis Boone, a Davidson County planning commissioner.

Dan set the Gaddis book on his knee and listened.

Holmes continued. Ballistics testing matched the recovered rounds to Boone's weapon. Boone had visited the Hendersonville Firearms Range on four occasions in the three months prior to the killing. Records from the range confirmed dates and lane reservations. Boone and the victim had a documented history of conflict — public meetings, email exchanges, a confrontation at a planning commission session witnessed by three city employees.

"Based on this evidence," Caldwell said, "what was your conclusion?"

"The evidence pointed to Mr. Boone. We made the arrest on the morning of April sixteenth."

"Did you have reason to consider other suspects?"

"No. The ballistics match, the documented disputes, and the defendant's demonstrated familiarity with firearms gave us a clear direction. We followed it."

Caldwell nodded and moved to the timeline. Holmes laid it out: Kinsey's last confirmed contact was a phone call at 8:17 PM on April fourteenth, from a prepaid number that was never identified. The body was found at 6:42 the following morning by the owner of the tax preparation business, arriving to open. Boone told investigators he'd been home alone that evening. No alibi witness.

Dan's hands were still on his knees. His thumb hadn't moved on the cover in twenty minutes.

Two rounds, both center mass, under ten feet. In a dark parking lot with one working light on the wrong side. Holmes was describing it as the result of an angry man with a gun and some range practice. Dan had heard that description before — prosecutors loved it, juries understood it, it made a clean story. But four trips to an indoor range, shooting paper targets under fluorescent lights at a marked distance, didn't produce two clean shots to the chest in the dark. That took something else.

He shifted the book on his knee and looked at the front of the courtroom.

Ms. Barr stood without notes.

“Detective Holmes, you mentioned the defendant visited a shooting range four times. What was his accuracy record at the range?”

Holmes paused. “I don’t have that information.”

“You didn’t check?”

“The range confirmed his visits. That established familiarity with the weapon.”

“Familiarity,” Barr repeated. “Four visits to an indoor range. Paper targets, good lighting, no stress, no time pressure. And from that, you concluded he was capable of putting two rounds in the center of a man’s chest at close range, in a dark parking lot, presumably in an emotional confrontation — and hitting perfectly both times?”

“Range training establishes—”

“Have you ever fired a weapon under stress, Detective?”

“I have.”

“And would you describe it as comparable to firing at a paper target?”

Holmes shifted in the chair. “They’re different situations.”

“They are.” Barr let that sit. “The ballistics match, Detective. It tells us the rounds came from that gun.”

“Yes.”

“Does it tell us whose hand was on it?”

“No. The rest of the evidence does that.”

“We’ll come to the rest.” Then: “Detective, when you informed Mr. Boone of the ballistics match, what did he say?”

“He said the gun should be in his nightstand.”

“Before you’d finished explaining the match.”

“About then.”

“And was it in his nightstand?”

“No. It was in our custody. We’d recovered it from the dumpster the previous morning.”

“So he learned from you that his own gun was gone. And that statement is in your report.”

“It is.”

“Did you investigate it — the possibility that the weapon had been taken from his home?”

“There were no signs of forced entry.”

“Did you examine the locks?”

“We looked at the doors.”

“What kind of lock was on the back door, Detective?”

A pause. “I don’t recall.”

“You don’t recall.” Barr repeated it, flat, and moved on. “Detective, was gunshot residue testing performed on the defendant?”

“It was.”

“What were the results?”

“Negative. No GSR was detected on the defendant’s hands or clothing.”

“And your explanation for that?”

“The arrest was made on the morning of the sixteenth. The defendant had a day and a half to shower, change clothes, and dispose of any contaminated garments.”

“A day and a half,” Barr said. “Detective, you spoke with Mr. Boone at his home the morning after the shooting, didn’t you?”

“My partner and I. A routine contact. He’d had public disputes with the victim.”

“About twelve hours after Mr. Kinsey was shot. Did anyone test his hands that morning?”

“He wasn’t a suspect that morning.”

“So the day and a half was time your department gave him.”

“So you tested, found nothing, and concluded the absence of evidence was itself explained by the evidence you didn’t find?”

Caldwell stood. “Objection. Argumentative.”

The judge looked at Barr over his glasses. “Rephrase, counselor.”

Barr didn’t miss a beat. “Detective, you tested the defendant for gunshot residue and the results were negative. No residue on his hands, no residue on his clothing. Isn’t a negative result evidence that the defendant did not fire a weapon?”

“Not necessarily. GSR can be washed off, clothing can be changed—”

“But you found no residue. That’s a fact. And you set it aside.”

“Because the direction was already set.” Barr glanced at the jury box — a quick sweep, left to right, checking where attention was landing. “Detective Holmes, did you investigate any other suspects in connection with Garrett Kinsey’s death?”

Something tightened in Holmes’s jaw. “The evidence pointed clearly to the defendant from the beginning. The ballistics match alone—”

“Detective.” The judge’s voice was quiet. “Answer the question.”

Holmes looked at the judge, then back at Barr. “No. We did not investigate other suspects.”

“Were there other individuals who had professional disputes with Garrett Kinsey?”

“Mr. Kinsey was a land broker. Disputes were part of his business.”

“So there were others.”

“There are always others in that line of work. But none of them had a ballistics match.”

“Because you didn’t test their weapons.”

Holmes didn’t answer. Barr didn’t need him to.

“One more question, Detective. The weapon was recovered from a dumpster in the alley, approximately forty yards from the victim’s body. Is that correct?”

“That’s correct.”

“A gun bought by the defendant. In his name. Serial number on the purchase record. Disposed of forty yards from the body — not in the Cumberland River, not in a storm drain on the other side of town, but right there in the alley behind the building.”

Holmes waited.

“Does that strike you as the behavior of a man trying to get away with murder?”

Caldwell stood. “Objection. Calls for speculation.”

“Sustained,” the judge said.

Barr nodded. She didn’t need the answer. The question was the point.

“No further questions,” she said, and sat down.

The judge called a recess. Then he brought them back, heard a procedural motion from Caldwell about exhibit scheduling, and dismissed the jury for the day at three-fifteen.

Dan filed out with the others. The hallway outside the courtroom was fluorescent-lit and smelled like the coffee urn from the jury assembly room down the hall. Jurors moved toward the elevators in ones and twos, checking phones, pulling on jackets.

Halfway down the hall, near the water fountain, Travis Boone stood with the couple from the gallery. The short, round woman had both hands on a foil-wrapped package she was pressing into Travis's arms. She was saying something about it — instructions, probably, reheating temperatures. The tall man in the plaid shirt stood a step behind, one hand on his son's shoulder, not speaking. Travis held the package and nodded at whatever his mother was telling him.

Parents. Dan had known them from the first morning: the woman from the driveway, the man from the porch. Every day since, they'd sat in the back row with the particular focus of people whose child was at the center of it. Now, watching the mother hand her son dinner in a courthouse hallway, it landed differently.

He walked past them to the elevator, pressed the button, and waited with his hands in his pockets. The doors opened. He stepped in, turned around, and caught one last glimpse of Travis Boone holding the package against his chest, his mother's hands still adjusting the edges, his father's hand still on his shoulder.

The doors closed. Dan rode down alone.

Chapter 11 — The Witness

The prosecution had rested before the weekend, after two more witnesses Dan could have summarized in a sentence each — a shooting range employee who confirmed Travis’s visits, and a city worker who’d seen Travis and Kinsey argue at a planning session. Barr had handled both on cross in under five minutes apiece, asking just enough to establish that neither witness had seen anything related to the actual murder. Caldwell was tidy. He’d built his case, thanked the jury, and sat down.

Now it was Barr’s turn.

“The defense calls Roosevelt Hayes,” she said.

The man who came through the side door moved slowly and didn’t apologize for it. He was eighty-three or eighty-four — slight, narrow through the chest, with deep-set eyes in a face that had been collecting lines for decades. He wore a brown suit with wide lapels that hadn’t been in style since the Carter administration and a tie with a thin gold stripe. His hands were long-fingered and careful, and he gripped the rail of the witness box as he stepped up and lowered himself into the chair.

The bailiff held the Bible. Hayes placed his left hand on it and raised his right and was sworn in with the same unhurried patience he’d used to cross the room.

“Mr. Hayes,” Barr said. “How old are you?”

“Eighty-three.”

“And what did you do for a living?”

“I was a musician. Played bass. Some guitar when they needed it.”

“Where did you play?”

Hayes looked at her as if she’d asked him where the sun came up. “Everywhere. Clubs on Jefferson Street, churches, session work. I played the Ryman once, backing up a gospel group from Memphis. But mostly I played the studios.”

“Which studios?”

“Crown Recording, mostly. That was the one. Little place over on Edgehill, off Music Row.”

Barr let him settle into it. She asked when he’d first recorded at Crown, and Hayes said 1958. He was fifteen. A friend named Lester Devine had been cutting a single there — an R&B number, something about a train — and needed a bass player for the session. Hayes showed up with his instrument and didn’t leave for ten years.

“What was Crown Recording?” Barr asked.

“It was a studio. Two rooms — the live room and the booth. The live room had concrete floors and wood paneling on the walls, and the ceiling was low enough that if you raised your trombone too high you’d hit a tile. The booth had a four-track board that Mr. Wardell built himself from parts he ordered out of a catalogue.”

“Mr. Wardell?”

“James Wardell. He owned the place. Built it in his building — it had been a print shop before that, and a barbershop before that. He put in the soundproofing himself. It wasn’t fancy. But the room sounded right. Some rooms do.”

Hayes talked about Crown the way a man talks about a house he grew up in. The equipment was secondhand. The microphones were borrowed or bought at surplus. The piano had a dead key — B-flat above middle C — that they worked around so long it became part of the sound. Artists came through because the big studios on Music Row wouldn’t book them, or wouldn’t book them at rates they could afford. Crown would.

“Who recorded there?” Barr asked.

“Everybody who was making music on this side of town. Lester Devine cut four singles there. Bobby Elam recorded his first album at Crown — *After Midnight*, 1961. Bobby went on to tour with Ray Charles for three years after that. The Fairfield Singers did all their early sessions at Crown — gospel, but they could sing anything. Marian Telford came through twice, once for a demo that never got released and once for a session that did.”

Dan had stopped fidgeting with the Gaddis. The book was still on his knee, but his hands were motionless on the cover. Marian Telford had recorded at this studio. He knew the name — a contralto out of Fisk who'd sung at the March on Washington in '63 and cut two albums for a Chicago label before disappearing from the industry. He'd seen her name in a discography six months ago, cross-referenced in a footnote. She'd recorded in Nashville, but the source hadn't specified where.

Now he knew where.

He sat very still and listened.

"Mr. Hayes," Barr said. "Was Crown Recording used for anything besides music?"

Hayes nodded slowly. "It was a meeting place. Mr. Wardell opened the studio to the community — voter registration drives, NAACP chapter meetings, planning for the sit-ins. The students from Fisk and Tennessee State used the back room for organizing. They'd meet on a Tuesday and we'd record on a Wednesday, same room, same folding chairs pushed against the wall."

"The sit-ins," Barr said. "You're referring to the Nashville lunch counter sit-ins of 1960?"

"Yes, ma'am. Some of those students planned their routes in the back room at Crown. Mr. Wardell fed them and let them use his telephone." Hayes paused. "He didn't make speeches about it. He just opened the door."

The courtroom was quiet. Gary Burris had stopped writing on his notepad. The woman in the third chair was watching Hayes with her hands in her lap. Even the straight-backed man with the white hair had set his pen down.

"Mr. Hayes, do you know how the defendant, Travis Boone, became aware of Crown Recording's history?"

"He called me. About a year and a half ago. Said he was a planning commissioner reviewing a development project on the site, and he'd found some references to the building in city records — the original permits, a zoning variance from 1956 that listed the business as a recording studio. He wanted to know if anyone was still alive who remembered it."

“And what did you tell him?”

“I told him I remembered it just fine.”

“Did Mr. Boone ask you to do anything?”

“He asked me to write down what I remembered. Dates, names, sessions — anything I could put on paper. He said he was putting together a filing for the historical commission. He wanted documentation.”

“And did you provide that?”

“I did. Took me about three weeks. I wrote eleven pages.” Hayes looked at the jury box. “I’m a slow typist.”

A few jurors smiled. Dan didn’t. He was watching Hayes’s hands on the armrest of the witness chair — the long fingers, the knuckles swollen with age, the hands that had played bass on sessions with Bobby Elam and Marian Telford in a room with a dead B-flat and concrete floors and the ghost of a movement that changed a city.

“Mr. Hayes,” Barr said. “In your interactions with Mr. Boone, did he ever express anger toward the developers? Toward Garrett Kinsey?”

“No, ma’am. He was interested in the history. He asked his questions and he wrote things down and he said he’d do what he could through the commission. That’s what he told me — ‘I’ll do what I can through the proper channels.’”

Barr had what she wanted. She thanked Hayes and sat down.

Caldwell stood for cross-examination. He asked Hayes whether he was being compensated for his testimony. Hayes said no. Caldwell asked whether Hayes had any personal relationship with the defendant. Hayes said he’d spoken to him twice on the telephone and once at a coffee shop on Jefferson Street. Caldwell asked whether Hayes had any expertise in forensic evidence, crime scene investigation, or ballistics. Hayes said he did not. Caldwell thanked him and sat down.

He’d asked nothing about the studio. Nothing about the history. Nothing about what Travis Boone had found or why he’d fought to protect it. He treated Hayes as irrelevant to the murder charge, which was technically

correct and strategically a mistake, because the jury had just spent forty minutes listening to an old man describe a place that mattered, and now the prosecutor had told them it didn't.

The judge dismissed the jury at four-ten. Dan stood with the others and filed toward the door. He left the Gaddis in his jacket pocket and walked out of the courtroom with his hands at his sides, and he did not look at Travis Boone as he passed the defense table, because he was afraid of what his face might show if he did.

Chapter 12 — After the Music

Travis stood on the porch for a while before going inside.

He hadn't done that since the arrest — just stood out here, leaning against the railing, watching the street. Fatherland Street in the early evening was dog walkers and joggers and people carrying groceries from the car to the door. Normal life. The bicycle was still locked to the railing beside him, the tires soft, the chain starting to rust. He put his hand on the seat and left it there for a moment, then went inside.

He changed out of the suit and the blue shirt and put on jeans and a t-shirt and stood in the kitchen looking at the refrigerator. He opened it. There was leftover chicken from the foil package his mother had brought yesterday, and some vegetables, and a block of cheese that was still good. He pulled out the chicken and the vegetables and turned on the stove.

While the pan heated, he leaned against the counter and thought about Roosevelt Hayes.

For forty minutes the trial had been about something besides ballistics and parking lots and a dead man on Dickerson Pike. Whether the jury cared was a different question. Caldwell would say it in closing, probably with sympathy: *We all appreciate Mr. Hayes's perspective, but the question before you isn't whether Crown Recording was a significant place. The question is whether the defendant killed Garrett Kinsey.* And he'd be right, legally. That was the problem.

He'd watched them during the testimony. Not all of them were listening — a man in the back row had been studying his fingernails, and a woman near the end had been looking at the clock. But some of them had been there, in the room, hearing it. The woman in the third chair had sat with her hands in her lap, watching Hayes as if he were someone's grandfather telling a story at Thanksgiving. The heavyset man with the phone holster — Gary, the one who'd said people don't get arrested for no reason — had stopped writing on his notepad for the first time all week. And the professor in the ninth seat, the one who'd given the careful answer during jury selection, had closed his book. He'd had it on his knee through most of the trial, turning it over in his hands, fidgeting with the cover, but today he'd set it face-down on

his knee and listened to Hayes describe a recording session from 1961 with both hands still.

He turned the chicken in the pan and added the vegetables.

While he ate — at the table, not standing at the counter, which was itself a change he noticed and didn't examine — a memory surfaced.

Eight or nine months before the arrest, at a commission meeting. Kinsey had been there, sitting in the back during public comment, not speaking. Afterward, in the hallway, Travis had passed him near the elevator. Kinsey was on the phone, turned away, his voice low but not low enough. Travis caught a fragment: “...told him it's not worth the exposure. He doesn't listen. He never listens.”

Kinsey had seen Travis and stopped talking. They'd looked at each other for a beat — two men who'd argued in public about the same piece of ground — and then Kinsey turned and walked the other way, the phone still at his ear.

Travis hadn't thought about it since. The fragment was meaningless at the time — Kinsey was a broker, he was always on the phone, always managing someone. But now, sitting at his kitchen table with the “two problems” theory turning slowly in his head, the fragment fit. *He doesn't listen. He never listens.* Kinsey talking about the developer boss. Kinsey worried about exposure. Kinsey trying to pull back from something and being told no.

If Kinsey had wanted out and the boss wouldn't let him — if Kinsey had started to look like a liability instead of an asset — then killing him and framing Travis solved both problems at once. The broker who might talk and the commissioner who wouldn't stop.

Travis set his fork down and stared at the table. He couldn't prove any of it. A fragment of a phone call overheard in a hallway. He hadn't even heard the name.

His mother called at seven-fifteen.

“Your father got a parking ticket today,” she said. “Can you believe that? Thirty-five dollars. He said he put enough in the meter, and I said then how did you get a ticket, and he said the meter must be broken.”

“Was it broken?”

“Of course it wasn’t broken. He’s cheap.” She paused. “That man today. The musician. He had such lovely hands.”

Travis waited.

“Long fingers,” she said. “Like a piano player. But he said he played bass.”

“He did.”

She didn’t say anything. It was the closest she’d come to talking about the trial since opening day, and they both knew it. She pulled back before she got any closer.

“Are you eating real food tonight?”

“Chicken and vegetables.”

“From what I brought?”

“Yes, Mom.”

“Good.” She told him his father was already asleep in the recliner and that the tomatoes were going to be wonderful this year and that she’d see him at nine. She said she loved him and hung up.

Barr called at eight.

“Today was good,” she said. No preamble — she’d decided it and was telling him. “The jury was listening. Not all of them, but enough.”

“Is ‘enough’ a legal term?”

“It’s a Barr term. It means I know what I saw.” She paused. “My investigator pulled the corporate filings on Kinsey. He was contracted to Carsten Properties as the exclusive land broker for Harmony Ridge. It’s documented — engagement letter, fee structure, everything. He was their man, Travis. On paper and on the record.”

“I know he was their man. I’ve been saying that for months.”

“Now we can prove it. I’m going to enter the filings as a defense exhibit — get the connection on the record. Once the jury sees that Kinsey was working for the same developers Travis was blocking, the prosecution’s motive theory starts to look very different.”

Travis let that land. It was the first piece of his theory that had moved from his head into Barr’s filing cabinet.

He told her about the hallway then: Kinsey by the elevator, the phone, *he doesn’t listen, he never listens*. He’d only just remembered it himself, and it came out in the wrong order.

Barr didn’t answer right away. “Did he say a name?”

“No.”

“Then it’s a fragment from eight months ago with no name in it. The only way it reaches a jury is you on the stand, and then Caldwell spends an afternoon reading your emails to Kinsey out loud.” She let him hear it. “Write it down tonight, everything you remember, and date it. It’s not nothing. It’s just not for this trial.”

Travis said he would.

“Tomorrow,” Barr said. “I’ve got a second witness — a woman who grew up in the neighborhood near Crown. She was a teenager when the sit-ins were happening, used to go to the studio with her older brother. Caldwell will object.”

“On what grounds?”

“Cumulative. Irrelevant to the charges. He’ll say we’ve already heard about the studio and that additional testimony on the same subject is a waste of the court’s time.”

“And the judge?”

“The judge will ask me to argue relevance. And I will.” There was something in her voice — not quite satisfaction, but controlled energy — she’d been waiting for this opening and had just seen it appear. “I’ll argue that the defendant’s motive is central to the prosecution’s case, and that the historical significance of the site is directly relevant to establishing that

the defendant had a legitimate, documented, evidence-based reason for his dispute with the victim. Caldwell objects, and I get to make that argument in front of the jury before the judge rules.”

“And if the judge sustains?”

“Then the jury heard me say it anyway. And if he overrules, I get the witness too.”

Travis almost laughed. It was the first time in weeks he’d felt anything close to humor, and it came from a lawyer explaining how to turn an objection into a stage.

“Get some sleep,” she said. “Nine o’clock. Blue shirt again — it’s working.”

He washed the plate and the pan and put them in the rack. He stood at the kitchen window and looked at the dark beyond the glass. The bungalow was quiet, but it was a different quiet tonight — not the hollow silence of a life that had contracted, but the held breath of a house waiting to see what happened next.

He checked the deadbolt on the back door out of habit and went to bed. The nightstand was on his left, the drawer still empty. But he fell asleep faster than he had in weeks, and he didn’t dream about the gun that used to be there.

Chapter 13 — The Defense Rests

Caldwell was on his feet before Barr finished the name.

“Objection, Your Honor. The defense called a witness yesterday who testified at length about the recording studio. This is cumulative and irrelevant to the charges before the court.”

The judge looked at Barr. “Ms. Barr?”

Barr stood behind the defense table, one hand resting on the edge. “Your Honor, the prosecution has made the defendant’s motive a central element of its case. Mr. Caldwell spent his opening statement describing a pattern of escalating conflict between my client and the victim. The historical significance of the development site is directly relevant to establishing that the defendant had a legitimate, documented, evidence-based reason for his dispute with Mr. Kinsey — a reason that had nothing to do with personal anger and everything to do with professional responsibility. This witness brings a different perspective from Mr. Hayes. She can speak to the community impact of the site, not just its musical history. That is not cumulative. It is context the jury deserves to hear.”

Caldwell didn’t respond. He’d said his piece. He stood with his hands clasped in front of him and waited for the ruling.

The judge took off his glasses and cleaned them on his tie, which Dan had noticed he did when he was thinking. He put them back on.

“I’ll allow the witness,” he said. “Ms. Barr, keep it focused. I want testimony relevant to the defendant’s state of mind and his reasons for the dispute. Not a history lesson.”

“Understood, Your Honor.”

The side door opened and the witness walked in.

She was about eighty, tall and spare, with high cheekbones and gray hair braided close to her head. She wore a green dress and low heels and carried her purse to the witness stand, where she set it on the floor beside the chair before sitting down. She was sworn in and stated her name — Dorothy

Givens — and looked at Barr with the composed patience of someone who'd been asked to wait before and hadn't minded.

"Ms. Givens," Barr said. "Where did you grow up?"

"On Edgehill Avenue. Three blocks from the building you've been talking about."

"Crown Recording Studio."

"That's right. Though we didn't call it that. We called it Wardell's."

She'd been fourteen in 1960, the year the sit-ins started. Her older brother, Raymond, was a student at Tennessee State and had gone to meetings at Wardell's building — the back room, the one with the folding chairs. Dorothy would walk him there after school sometimes and sit outside on the steps listening to whatever was coming through the walls. Some days it was music. Some days it was people talking about where to sit and what to do when they got dragged off the stool.

"The building was part of the neighborhood," she said. "It wasn't a museum. It was a place you walked past on your way to school. You heard piano through the windows in the afternoon. And then one day you heard your brother and his friends in there talking about going to Woolworth's, and you understood that the building was more than what it looked like from the outside."

Barr asked her two more questions. Did she know what happened to Crown Recording after the sixties? Givens said Mr. Wardell closed it in 1970, and the building changed hands a few times after that. It had been empty for years before the development company bought the lot.

Had Travis Boone contacted her?

"He did. Called me last year. Said he'd found my name in some records Mr. Hayes had given him — I was listed as a contact for the neighborhood history project in 2014. He asked me what I remembered about the building. I told him what I just told you." She paused. "He listened carefully. He wrote things down. He didn't seem angry about anything. He seemed like someone who'd found something that mattered and wanted to make sure it was documented before it got knocked down."

“Thank you, Ms. Givens,” Barr said.

Caldwell stood. He looked at Givens for a moment, then said, “No questions,” and sat back down.

The whole thing had taken eight minutes.

“Your Honor,” Barr said. “The defense would like to enter a document as Defense Exhibit Four.”

The judge looked at the exhibit. “What is this?”

“Corporate filings from the Tennessee Secretary of State’s office documenting the business relationship between Garrett Kinsey and Carsten Properties, the developer behind the Harmony Ridge project on the Crown Recording site. The filings show that Mr. Kinsey was contracted as the exclusive land broker for the project.”

“Who’s authenticating?”

Barr called a records clerk from the Secretary of State’s office — a young woman in a gray blazer who took the stand, confirmed the filings were authentic public records, and was excused in under three minutes. Caldwell watched from his chair and said nothing.

The judge admitted the exhibit.

Dan’s thumb stopped on the cover of the Gaddis.

Carsten Properties. He’d seen the name on the construction fence on Music Row, on the banner that read HARMONY RIDGE DEVELOPMENT. He’d heard it from the broker, months ago, in the flat shorthand of a contract briefing — *real estate development outfit, Nashville-based*. Now it was on a document being passed to the jury, entered into evidence in a murder trial where Dan sat in the ninth chair and the defendant sat at a table twenty feet away.

His thumb moved. He adjusted the book on his knee and looked at the judge.

Barr wasn't finished. "Your Honor, the defense would also like to enter Defense Exhibit Five — accuracy records from the Hendersonville Firearms Range for the defendant's four visits."

The judge looked at Caldwell. Caldwell glanced at the records and shook his head. "No objection."

The exhibit was admitted without testimony — the range had provided the records under subpoena, and their authenticity wasn't in dispute.

"Ms. Barr," the judge said. "Does the defense have further witnesses?"

Barr stood. "No, Your Honor. The defense rests."

The judge nodded. He told the jury that closing arguments would be heard the following morning at nine. He reminded them, again, not to discuss the case, not to read coverage, not to form opinions. He thanked them for their patience. He dismissed them.

Dan filed out with the others. He did not look at the defense table.

Dan hung his jacket, made coffee, and stood at the kitchen window watching the last light fade over the rooftops of Hillsboro Village. He'd been doing this for over a week now — courthouse to car to apartment, the same route, the same evening rituals, the same empty rooms.

He opened the kitchen drawer and took out the prepaid. No messages. He set it on the counter and waited.

It rang at seven-forty.

"How's Nashville?" the broker said. Same opening. Same tone — flat, a man checking on a deliverable.

"Quiet," Dan said. "Trial's wrapping up. Closing arguments tomorrow, then the jury gets it."

"What's your read? From where you sit."

Dan almost smiled at that. "Could go either way. The prosecution's case is solid but the defense poked some holes."

“If he walks?”

“Then I assess the situation and we talk.”

“The client’s been patient,” the broker said. “But patient has a shelf life. You know that.”

“I know that.”

“When the trial ends, I need a timeline. Not a plan — just a timeline.”

“You’ll have one.”

The broker said goodnight the way he said everything — like he was closing a tab on a screen. Dan put the prepaid back in the drawer and pushed it shut.

He stood in the kitchen and listened to the quiet. Closing arguments in the morning. Caldwell would lay out his forensics and his timeline and his ballistics match and tell the jury that Travis Boone killed Garrett Kinsey. Barr would pull every thread she’d planted — the shot grouping, the GSR, the tunnel vision, the dumpster, the history, the connection between Kinsey and the developers — and ask the jury whether any of it added up to beyond a reasonable doubt.

Then twelve people would walk into a room and decide.

Dan would be one of them.

Chapter 14 — Closing Arguments

The courtroom felt different without witnesses. No one at the stand, no exhibits being passed, no objections to sustain or overrule. Just two tables, a jury, and the arguments that would decide it. The gallery was fuller than it had been all trial — the reporters had brought friends, or maybe the friends had brought notebooks of their own. Travis sat at the defense table in the blue shirt. The Gaddis was on Dan's knee, untouched.

Caldwell stood and buttoned his jacket.

He was good. Dan had known he would be — he'd watched the man build his case over the course of a week with the care of a bricklayer, and the closing was the capstone. Caldwell walked the jury through the evidence as he had his opening — laying each piece down in order. The ballistics match. The documented disputes. The range visits. The timeline — Kinsey dead between eight-thirty and ten, Travis home alone with no alibi.

"The defendant's weapon killed Garrett Kinsey," Caldwell said. "That is not disputed. The rounds recovered from the victim's body were fired from a nine-millimeter handgun purchased by Travis Boone. The defendant had the means, the motive, and the opportunity. The evidence establishes all three."

He addressed the dumpster. He didn't shy from it — he walked straight into it, which was smart. "The defense made a point about the weapon being recovered forty yards from the body. They want you to ask why the defendant would leave his own traceable gun in a dumpster near the scene. The answer is straightforward: because people who commit violent acts in anger don't think clearly about what comes next. Mr. Boone didn't plan this. He reacted. He shot a man he'd been arguing with for months, and then he did what panicked people do — he got rid of the weapon and he left. The disposal wasn't rational because the act wasn't rational."

He addressed the history. He did it with sympathy, which was the right move. "You heard testimony from Mr. Hayes and Ms. Givens about Crown Recording Studio. Their memories are genuine, and the history they described is real. But the question before you is not whether Crown Recording

was a significant place. The question is whether Travis Boone killed Garrett Kinsey. The history of a building does not change the ballistics of a bullet.”

He paused, looked at the jury, and brought it home. “Follow the evidence. It will lead you to the only verdict the facts support.”

He sat down. The courtroom was quiet.

Dan glanced at the gallery. In the back row, Travis’s mother was leaning forward in her seat, her purse clutched on her lap, her eyes fixed on the defense table. Travis’s father sat beside her with his arms at his sides for the first time Dan could remember — not crossed, not folded, just resting on his thighs, as if he’d forgotten the posture he’d held for two weeks. They were both watching Barr.

Barr stood. She didn’t button anything, didn’t carry notes, didn’t move to the front of the jury box. She stayed behind her table, the same spot she’d delivered her opening from. Her voice was even and steady.

“Beyond a reasonable doubt,” she said. “That’s the standard. Not probably. Not likely. Not ‘the evidence points in that direction.’ Beyond a reasonable doubt means you are certain enough to take a man’s freedom — to end the life he had before this trial and replace it with something else. That is what the prosecution is asking you to do. I’m asking you to consider whether they’ve earned it.”

She didn’t argue the gun. She mentioned it — “Travis Boone told Detective Holmes the gun was gone before the detective had finished his sentence, and you heard the detective admit that not one hour of police work was ever spent on where it went” — and moved on. She wasn’t going to win on means and she knew it.

She went to motive.

“Mr. Caldwell told you this was about a professional dispute that escalated. Two men who argued about a development project until one of them killed the other. But you heard what that dispute was actually about. You heard Roosevelt Hayes describe a recording studio where Black artists made music when the rest of Music Row wouldn’t open its doors. You heard Dorothy Givens describe a building where her brother and his classmates

planned the Nashville sit-ins. And you heard that Travis Boone found this history in city records, called the people who remembered it, asked them to write it down, and filed his findings with the historical commission.”

She paused. “That is not a man building toward violence. That is a man building a case — a paper case, with documents and interviews and proper channels. He had evidence. He had eleven pages of testimony from a man who was there. He had corporate filings showing that the victim, Garrett Kinsey, was contracted to the very developers whose project Travis was reviewing. A man with that kind of evidence doesn’t need a gun. He needs a filing cabinet.”

She moved to the contradictions. She took them one at a time, and she was precise.

“The prosecution says Travis Boone shot Garrett Kinsey in a moment of rage. Two rounds, both center mass, at close range in a dark parking lot. Detective Holmes told you this was consistent with someone who’d visited a shooting range four times. You’ve seen the range records — Defense Exhibit Five. Travis Boone was an average shooter. Consistent with a man who bought a gun for home security and went to the range a few times to learn how to use it. Not a marksman. Four visits to an indoor facility — paper targets, good lighting, no stress — and from that, the prosecution asks you to believe he fired two perfect shots under pressure in the dark. That is not rage. That is marksmanship. And the prosecution has not explained where it came from.”

“The prosecution tested the defendant for gunshot residue. The results were negative. No residue on his hands, no residue on his clothing. The prosecution’s explanation is that a day and a half passed and the defendant cleaned up — a day and a half the police handed him, after they’d already stood in his doorway. But the fact remains: they tested, they found nothing, and they moved on.”

“The defendant’s own weapon was recovered from a dumpster forty yards from the body. His name was on the serial number. Mr. Caldwell tells you this was panic — a man not thinking clearly after an act of violence. But the same prosecution is asking you to believe this man was precise enough to

put two rounds in the center of another man's chest. You cannot have both. Either he was controlled or he was panicked. The prosecution needs him to be both, and that is a contradiction they have not resolved."

Dan knew which. He sat in the ninth chair with his hands on his knees and listened to a defense attorney describe, almost exactly, a man like him.

"Detective Holmes investigated no other suspects. Garrett Kinsey was a land broker. He had professional disputes as a matter of course. Not one other person was investigated. The detective found his answer early and stopped looking."

She paused. Let the silence work.

"The prosecution is going to tell you to follow the evidence. I agree. Follow the evidence. But follow *their* evidence — the evidence they presented — and ask yourself whether the story they built around it holds together. They told you a story about an angry man who shot someone in a parking lot. But the shot grouping says controlled. The disposal says careless. The GSR says clean. The investigation says narrow. And the man at the defense table spent his time documenting history and filing paperwork through the proper channels." She looked at the jury. "The standard is beyond a reasonable doubt. I'd ask you to hold them to it."

She sat down.

Caldwell stood for rebuttal. He looked at the jury and spoke for less than thirty seconds. "The defense has offered you history and speculation. But the evidence is the evidence. The defendant's weapon fired the rounds that killed Garrett Kinsey. The defendant had documented conflicts with the victim. The defendant cannot account for his whereabouts on the night of the murder. Follow the evidence to its conclusion. Thank you."

He sat down. It was exactly what Barr had told them he would say.

The judge gave his instructions. He spoke for ten minutes — reasonable doubt, unanimous verdict, evidence only, no outside research, no speculation, no sympathy. He'd given these instructions a thousand times, and he

still believed every word. Dan listened and watched the other jurors listen. Gary Burris was nodding along. The white-haired man had his pen ready. The woman in the third chair had her hands folded in her lap.

The judge thanked them. He excused the two alternates, who gathered their things with the look of people sent home before the end of a movie. He told the rest that a bailiff would escort them to the jury room. He wished them well.

The jury stood. Dan stood with them. He left the Gaddis on the chair — he wouldn't need it where he was going. They filed out of the courtroom and down a short hallway to a door marked JURY ROOM, and the bailiff held it open, and they walked in one by one, twelve people who'd been sitting in the same box for a week and were now expected to agree on what it all meant.

Dan was the ninth one through the door.

The bailiff closed it behind them.

Chapter 15 — The Room

The bailiff closed the door and the twelve of them stood there.

The jury room was smaller than Dan had expected. A long table ran down the center, surrounded by chairs that didn't match — some padded, some wooden, all pushed in at odd angles from whoever had used the room last. A counter along the near wall held a coffee setup: drip machine, Styrofoam cups, a basket of sugar packets and powdered creamer. Above the counter, a row of tall windows looked out over a side street — a strip of pavement, a parked delivery truck, a woman in scrubs walking toward the hospital. Fluorescent lights hummed. A corkboard on the far wall had nothing pinned to it.

Dan noted the single door, the windows that didn't open, and chose a chair near the middle of the table.

People found seats. Some moved to specific spots as though the chairs had been assigned; others drifted. A heavyset man near the windows sat down and exhaled through his nose. Burris claimed the center of the table and placed his phone facedown in front of him like a place setting. The white-haired man — the straight back, the close-cropped hair, the pen Dan had been watching for a week — took the far end and opened a small notebook.

For a moment nobody spoke. Twelve people who'd spent a week sitting still were now supposed to decide something.

A woman across from Dan cleared her throat. "We should pick a foreperson."

She was maybe forty-five — dark-framed glasses, a blazer over a plain blouse. She glanced around the table. The meeting was already late.

"Anyone want to do it?"

Nothing.

"All right." She sat straighter. "I'll take it. Let's start with where everybody stands. Go around the table — guilty or not guilty. Say why if you want, but keep it brief. We're just getting a count."

She pointed to the man on her left.

“Not guilty.” He was older, retired maybe, and he spoke carefully. “I think the prosecution put together a credible case. The ballistics are serious. But I kept coming back to the standard, and I don’t think they got there.”

The woman beside him said not guilty. The GSR bothered her. “They tested him and found nothing. The prosecution says he had time to clean up, but that’s an explanation for a negative result, not evidence. The test came back clean. That should count for something.”

A few people around the table nodded.

Two more not-guilty votes came without much elaboration. One cited the dumpster — dumping your own traceable weapon forty yards from the body didn’t fit with two controlled rounds to the chest. The other said the standard hadn’t been met and left it there. Four.

Dan. “Not guilty,” he said. “The controlled shots and the panicked disposal didn’t add up for me.” He sat back. Five.

The woman next to him said not guilty. Six.

Then the first guilty vote. A thin man in frameless glasses spoke softly, almost apologetically. The ballistics troubled him. He believed the gun evidence and couldn’t find a way past it. He folded his hands after he spoke and looked at the table.

Burris.

“Guilty,” he said, with the settled confidence of a man filling out a form he’d already completed in his head. “The gun matched. That’s the evidence. His gun, his bullets.” He spread his hands on the table. “What else do you need?”

“The defense argued the gun was stolen from his home,” the woman to his left said.

“Right, but—” Burris shifted forward. “The thing is, though, the parking lot — the detective said there was only one way in and out, right? So whoever did this had to have known the layout, and Boone lives over in—”

“Let’s stay on one thing at a time,” the foreperson said. “We’ll get to the crime scene. You vote guilty?”

“That’s right.”

“Thank you.” She nodded to the next chair.

A woman in her thirties said guilty, barely above a murmur. She thought the evidence pointed in that direction but she said it without conviction, her eyes drifting toward the window as she finished. Soft vote. Reachable.

The foreperson looked at the white-haired man.

He set his pen down parallel to his notebook — aligned, precise — and spoke the way he’d probably spoken in briefings for thirty years.

“Guilty,” he said. “The defendant’s weapon fired the rounds that killed the victim. That’s not in dispute. The defendant had documented conflicts with the victim spanning months. He visited a shooting range four times in the period before the killing. He has no alibi for the night in question.”

He paused. Not for drama — he was organizing the next point.

“The defense offered alternative theories. The gun was stolen. The developers had motive. But no alternative suspect was presented. No one else was placed at the scene or connected to the weapon. Reasonable doubt is not any doubt. It’s a doubt you can articulate a reason for — grounded in the evidence, or the absence of evidence. I’ve looked at everything that was presented, and the prosecution’s case holds together.”

The room went quiet. Not because anyone felt cowed — because the argument was good. He’d taken Caldwell’s case and rebuilt it, tighter and cleaner, stripped to the frame and squared at the corners.

Dan watched him close his notebook. That was the wall. Not Burris, not the soft votes. This man would hold when everyone else moved.

The foreperson turned to the last chair.

The man sitting in it was in his forties — thick hands, knuckles that had been split and healed more than once. He wore a flannel shirt untucked over work boots. He’d said nothing the entire trial, sitting with his arms folded, watching.

“Guilty,” he said. His voice carried more heat than the word called for. “The evidence is there. His gun, his disputes. And this guy — he’s a planning commissioner. He tells people what they can and can’t build on their own property. He had that power, and he used it, and he thinks he can just—”

“We’re looking at the evidence,” the foreperson said. “Not the defendant’s job title.”

His jaw worked once. He sat back in his chair. “Evidence speaks for itself.”

It didn’t, but Dan understood what did. Years of permits and inspections and officials who could stop a man’s work with a form and a rubber stamp. Travis Boone wasn’t a person to this juror. He was every bureaucrat who’d ever told him no.

The foreperson made a mark on a legal pad she’d found in a drawer, then one more.

“That one’s mine. Not guilty — the detective never looked at anyone else.” She tapped the pad. “Seven not guilty, five guilty.” She set the pad down and looked around the table. “We’re not going to resolve this today. I suggest we come back tomorrow morning and work through the evidence point by point — ballistics, crime scene, timeline. One issue at a time.”

She looked around. “Anyone have a problem with that approach?”

Nobody spoke. Burris opened his mouth, considered it, and closed it.

“Good. I’ll let the bailiff know.”

Chairs scraped back from the table. Someone reached for the coffee carafe, looked at it, and set it down. The white-haired man capped his pen. Burris checked his phone. The man in the flannel shirt was already at the door.

The courthouse hallway was empty — the reporters gone, the gallery dark, the security guards at the front entrance starting to pack up the conveyor belt. Dan walked through the lobby and out into early evening. The air was warm and smelled faintly of diesel from Second Avenue.

Seven to five. Two of the guilty votes were soft — they'd come around when the arguments got specific. Burris was noise. The trades guy was personal, not evidential, and that made him harder to predict.

The principled holdout was the real problem. Dan had known men like that — certain, methodical, internally coherent. You didn't argue them out of a position. You had to show them something they hadn't accounted for.

He walked to his car and drove home.

Chapter 16 — The Waiting

Travis pulled the Tacoma into the driveway and sat there for a moment before getting out.

The bungalow looked the same as it had that morning — porch light on, bicycle chained to the railing, the new deadbolt catching the streetlight where the old brass one used to be. He'd left at seven-thirty to drive downtown and sit in a plastic chair in a hallway outside a courtroom while twelve people decided his life in a room he couldn't enter. Barr had told him to stay close in case the verdict came fast. It didn't come fast. He'd sat in the plastic chair and watched the hallway — clerks with folders, attorneys talking into phones, a janitor mopping the floor near the elevators with a bucket that smelled like pine. Around three, Barr had come out and told him the jury was done for the day, they'd be back tomorrow, go home. She'd said it evenly and touched his arm once before turning back inside.

Nine hours, and nobody had decided anything.

He locked the truck and went inside.

The house was warm — he'd forgotten the thermostat. He dropped his keys on the counter and opened the refrigerator. Leftover pasta from two nights ago, half a foil package from his mother that might have been cornbread. He pulled out the pasta and put it in the microwave and watched it turn behind the glass.

He ate standing at the counter, not tasting much. When he was done he rinsed the plate and fork and left them in the rack. The window over the sink was dark, his reflection looking back — still in the suit, hours after there'd been any reason to wear it.

He changed into jeans and the Predators shirt and went to the living room. Turned on the TV and scrolled until he found a movie. Something with cars and a plot he couldn't follow. He didn't try. He sat on the couch with his phone on the cushion beside him.

On the screen, a man drove fast through a city at night while another man shouted into a radio. Travis watched their mouths move. He picked up his phone, looked at it, set it back down. No messages. He put it on the arm

of the couch so he'd stop reaching for it. Two minutes later he reached for it. Barr had said she'd call when she heard anything. She hadn't called. He knew what that meant. He checked anyway.

Outside, a neighbor's screen door slapped shut. A kid yelled something, and another kid yelled something back, and then it was just the movie again — tires squealing, music rising, none of it landing.

The first days of testimony, he'd been able to occupy himself — there were arguments to replay, faces to study, the puzzle of which jurors were listening and which were enduring it. Now the arguments were finished and the faces were behind a closed door, and all Travis could do was sit on his couch and wait for a phone that wasn't ringing.

It rang at six-forty. His mother's number.

"Travis." Her voice was different — no preamble about parking or tomatoes or whether he was eating. "Your father's here too."

He heard the phone shift, the scrape of it being held between them or set on the counter.

"Hey, son," his father said. Low and unhurried — the same voice Travis had heard across the kitchen table for thirty years, across the carport when he came home from school, from the hallway outside his childhood bedroom when the lights were off. His father didn't call. His father sat in the gallery every day and held still and didn't speak.

"We just wanted to call," his mother said. "We're thinking about you and we need you to know that."

Travis sat on the couch with the movie playing and his phone against his ear. He didn't say anything for a moment.

"I know," he said.

"We'll be there in the morning," his mother said.

"I know you will."

His father said goodnight. His mother said she loved him. The call lasted under two minutes.

Travis set the phone on the cushion and looked at the TV without seeing it. Two weeks of parking meters and broken tomato cages and blue shirts, and tonight they'd just said it. No buffer. No safe topic to steer toward. They were frightened, and they'd called to say they loved him, and then they'd hung up because there was nothing else to do.

He closed his eyes and sat there for a while. The movie played to nobody. When he opened them the scene had changed — different cars, different city, a woman now, standing in the rain — and he had no idea how long he'd been sitting there.

Barr called at seven-fifteen.

"Nothing from the jury room," she said. "No notes, no questions."

"Is that normal?"

"First day. They're orienting. Don't read anything into it."

"Do you know the split?"

"That stays in the room. I won't know anything until the verdict comes out or the judge declares a mistrial." She paused. "There's no information to have right now, Travis. I know that's the hard part."

"I'm fine."

"You don't have to be. But there's nothing to do tonight except rest."

Travis looked at the dark window across the room. "Did you see anything? In the courtroom, before they went back?"

"I saw twelve people who listened to closing arguments all morning. Five or six were watching me more than Caldwell by the end. That's not a prediction. It's an observation."

"But it's something."

"It's something." She didn't oversell it. "Nine o'clock tomorrow. Get some sleep."

He turned off the TV. The bungalow settled around him — the refrigerator cycling on, a dog somewhere down the block, a car on Fatherland Street with its bass turned up, rattling past and gone. He got up from the couch and stood in the living room with his hands in his pockets, then went through the house.

Front door locked. He turned off the kitchen light and checked the back — the deadbolt the locksmith had put in for eleven hundred dollars, the one he tested every night even though the gun was already gone. Whatever they'd wanted from this house, they'd taken it months ago.

He brushed his teeth and turned off the lights and got into bed. He opened the nightstand drawer without thinking — habit he couldn't break. Empty, same as yesterday and the night before that. He'd stopped expecting to see the gun. He just couldn't stop checking. He pushed the drawer shut and rolled over.

Chapter 17 — The Map

Dan drove home from the courthouse, parked the Volvo, and walked to the Thai place on 21st. He ordered the green curry without looking at the menu. The woman behind the counter knew him — not his name, just his order and his face, which was the right amount of knowing. He paid cash and waited by the window while she packed it into a bag.

Hillsboro Village was doing its evening thing. Students from the university drifting between the bookstore and the coffee shop, a couple arguing quietly outside the pub, a man walking a dog that was too big for the sidewalk. The dog knew it. Dan watched them — not looking for anything, just looking. The curry came. He thanked the woman and walked home.

The apartment was warm. He set the food on the counter and went to the kitchen drawer by the coffee filters. The prepaid phone was where he'd left it that morning — he couldn't bring it through courthouse security, so every day it sat in the drawer while he sat in the jury box, and every evening he checked it like mail.

One missed call. No voicemail. He didn't need one.

He ate the curry standing at the counter, then rinsed the container and dropped it in the trash. Changed out of the khakis into jeans and a t-shirt. Pulled a beer from the refrigerator. Then he picked up the prepaid and called the number back.

The broker answered on the second ring.

"There he is."

"Here I am."

"How's Nashville?"

"Warm," Dan said. "Humid."

"I hear the jury's out on your boy."

"News travels."

"News is all there is right now." The broker's voice was the same as always — flat, unbothered, the tone of a man confirming a shipment date. But the

shipment was late, and they both knew it. “You did a lot of recon before this thing went sideways. I’d hate to see that go to waste.”

“It won’t.”

“Good. Because the client’s not going to want to start from scratch. He understands the situation changed, but the situation’s about to change back. Verdict comes in, your guy walks out of that courthouse, and we’re going to need to move.”

“I can be ready the same day,” Dan said. “Unless he gets acquitted and decides to celebrate in Mongolia.”

A pause. Then something that might have been a laugh, or might have been the broker shifting the phone. “Just be ready.”

“I’m ready.”

“Good. Talk soon.”

The line went dead. Dan set the phone on the counter and took a drink of the beer. The broker didn’t know he was on the jury. Nobody did. That was the only advantage he had, and it was the kind that evaporated the moment anyone looked at it too closely.

He sat on the couch and turned on the television — a basketball game, second quarter, neither team he followed. He watched it without watching it and thought about the jury room.

Seven to five. The foreperson had handled the first day well — structured, no-nonsense, kept Burris from derailing twice. She’d run it the same tomorrow, point by point through the evidence. That was fine. The format favored acquittal. When you broke the prosecution’s case into individual pieces and held each one up to the light, the gaps showed.

The two soft guilty votes would come around. The thin man with the frameless glasses had practically apologized for his vote — he was troubled by the ballistics and needed someone to walk him through the alternative. The woman who’d murmured her vote while looking at the window was even easier. She’d move with the room once the room moved.

Dan didn't need to lead that. Seven other people could make those arguments, and it was better if they did. A professor who pushed too hard for acquittal was a professor with an opinion. A professor who mostly listened and asked an occasional question was a professor doing his civic duty.

Burris was noise. Confident, sincere, logically backwards, and ultimately harmless. The foreperson would manage him, and the room would route around him the way a current routes around a rock.

The trades guy was harder to predict. His vote wasn't about evidence — it was about Travis Boone's job title and every planning commissioner who'd ever made his life difficult. You couldn't argue someone out of a grudge with forensic analysis. But if the principled holdout flipped, the trades guy would lose his anchor. He might hold alone out of stubbornness, but he might not.

Which left the holdout.

Dan set the beer on the coffee table and stared at the game. The holdout's argument was the best one in the room — organized, calm, built from the evidence without embellishment. No alternative suspect was presented. No one else was placed at the scene or connected to the weapon. Reasonable doubt is not any doubt.

And Dan couldn't touch it. Not without offering the alternative the holdout was asking for, and he couldn't offer that without explaining how he knew. A history professor from Hillsboro Village had no business knowing what a professional hit looked like, or why the frame on Travis Boone had seams if you knew where to press.

He'd have to find another way in. Something in the evidence itself — something the holdout had weighed and could be asked to weigh again. Not a new argument. A new angle on an old one.

He didn't have it yet.

On the television, someone hit a three-pointer and the crowd noise swelled and faded. Dan picked up the remote and muted it. The apartment was quiet — the hum of the refrigerator, a car passing on the street below, a whole building emptied out for the evening.

The dissertation was on the desk in the corner, where it had been since before the trial. He'd ordered it through interlibrary loan two weeks before the Boone contract came in — a coincidence he'd noted at the time and hadn't thought about since. African American music venues in the mid-South, 1945 to 1968. Three hundred and twelve pages, dense with footnotes, exactly the kind of thing he read for no reason anyone in his other life would understand.

He picked it up and carried it back to the couch.

He found the section on Nashville without trying — he'd dog-eared it weeks ago. The chapter covered the studios that operated outside the Music Row establishment: small rooms, independent operators, Black artists who couldn't get booked at the bigger places. Crown Recording was a footnote on page 174, citing a 1962 newspaper feature about James Wardell and the musicians who passed through his building on Edgehill Avenue. Marian Telford was mentioned once, in a parenthetical he'd read past the first time, as having recorded there before signing with a Chicago label.

Dan read the passage twice. The dissertation treated Crown as a minor footnote — one of dozens of small studios that came and went. But Roosevelt Hayes had sat in the witness box and talked about it like it was a cathedral. The concrete floors, the dead B-flat on the piano, the four-track board Wardell had built from catalogue parts. The voter registration meetings in the same room where Bobby Elam cut his first album. The sit-in planning, the Fisk students, the phone Wardell let them use.

Travis Boone had found all of that in city records and gone through the proper channels to protect it. And someone had killed a man and framed Travis to make sure those channels led nowhere.

Dan closed the dissertation and set it on the cushion beside him. The basketball game played silently on the screen — tiny figures running patterns on a bright court. He watched them for a while, which was not something he was good at. Then he turned off the television and went to bed.

Tomorrow he'd walk back into the jury room with a map of every vote and no way through the wall. The answer would have to come from inside the room, under pressure, in the moment. It usually did.

Chapter 18 — The Room Moves

The coffee was worse on the second day. Someone had made it too early and it had been sitting on the burner, and the first cup Dan poured tasted like it had opinions about being reheated. He drank it anyway and took his seat.

The foreperson was already at the head of the table with her legal pad and a pen she'd brought from home. She waited until the last juror sat — the trades guy, who came in after everyone else and took his chair without looking at anyone — then opened her notebook.

"Yesterday we got a count. Today we start working through the evidence. Ballistics first. Then the crime scene." She looked around the table. "I want to hear from both sides. One person at a time. Stay on the topic."

She nodded at the room. For a moment nobody spoke. Then a woman near the far end — one of the early not-guilty votes — leaned forward.

"The gun was his. That's not in question. But the defense argued it was stolen from his home. He didn't even know it was gone until the detective told him about the ballistics match."

"That's the claim," the holdout said from his end of the table. His pen was already parallel to his notebook. "But no evidence of a break-in was presented. No police report, no damaged lock, no witnesses. The defense argued theft. They didn't prove it."

"They don't have to prove it," someone said. "They have to raise doubt."

"Reasonable doubt. Not speculative doubt." The holdout's voice was even. He wasn't arguing — he was defining terms. "A theory without supporting evidence is speculation."

The thin man with the frameless glasses had been listening with his hands folded on the table. "What about the shot grouping? The detective said two rounds, center mass, under ten feet. The defense attorney asked about that — she said it was inconsistent with someone acting out of rage."

“People don’t shoot in patterns when they’re angry,” a man across the table said. He was older, heavysset, one of the original not-guilty votes. “They shoot wild. Two clean shots to the chest — that’s either training or practice.”

“The defendant visited a shooting range four times,” the holdout said.

“Four times. I’ve been to the range more than four times and I couldn’t put two rounds center mass under pressure.” The heavysset man shook his head. “That’s not a guy who goes to the range on weekends.”

Burris shifted in his chair. “Well, but the thing is — a nine-millimeter, that’s a pretty accurate weapon at close range. I mean, if you’re standing right there, ten feet, you don’t really need to be a marksman. The bullet’s going to go where you point it.”

The foreperson looked at him.

“That’s not — the caliber doesn’t determine accuracy at that distance,” the heavysset man said. “The shooter does.”

“Right, no, I’m saying the gun itself—”

“Let’s stay on the grouping question,” the foreperson said. “The point is whether four range visits explain two precise shots under stress. Keep going.”

The room kept going. Three more people spoke — the GSR came up again, the day-and-a-half window the prosecution relied on to explain the negative test, the absence of casings at the scene. The not-guilty side had the arguments and the numbers, and the arguments got sharper as more people made them. Dan listened. The thin man had unfolded his hands and was turning his glasses over slowly, frowning at something no one had said yet.

The holdout answered each point with something reasonable. The negative GSR was explained by the time gap — a day and a half is enough to shower and change. No casings meant the killer collected them, and nothing about collecting them excluded the defendant. He wasn’t reaching. He was working with the same evidence and arriving at a different conclusion, and his conclusions held together.

“What about the dumpster?” the woman near the far end said. “His own gun, serial number intact, thrown in a dumpster right behind the building. If he planned this, why not get rid of the gun somewhere else? And if he didn’t plan it, how did he put two rounds center mass?”

The holdout paused. “Panic. A first-time killing — he’s not thinking clearly. He fires, he runs, he throws the weapon.”

“Into the nearest dumpster.”

“People in crisis don’t optimize their decisions.”

The foreperson made a note and looked around. “I think we’ve been through ballistics. Let’s move to the crime scene.”

The shift in topic brought new voices. Someone described the parking lot — rear of the strip mall, one working light pole, one way in and out. Another juror said it felt deliberate. The foreperson asked what they meant. “It’s not a place you end up accidentally. You go there because you have a reason to be behind a strip mall at night.”

Dan had been quiet for forty minutes. He leaned back in his chair and rubbed his jaw.

“The thing that keeps bothering me,” he said, “is that nothing the prosecution described is the same person.” He paused like he was working it out as he spoke. “The detective testified that no shell casings were recovered at the scene. None. A nine-millimeter ejects its casings — we all agree the gun was a nine-millimeter. So somebody picked them up. That’s not something you do in a panic. That’s careful. That’s someone thinking clearly enough to get on his hands and knees in a parking lot and collect his shell casings.”

“But this same person — this careful, methodical person — takes his own gun, serial number on it, and dumps it in the nearest dumpster. Doesn’t wipe it. Doesn’t take it home. Doesn’t throw it off a bridge on the drive back. Just tosses it forty yards away and leaves.” He looked at the table, not at anyone. “Those aren’t the same person. One of them is careful and the other one is reckless, and the prosecution needs us to believe it was both, in the same three minutes.”

He sat back. “And on top of that — why would Boone go to that parking lot at all? He and Kinsey had their disputes in public. Council meetings, emails. If Boone wanted a confrontation, he’d have it in a conference room, not behind a strip mall on Dickerson Pike. And Boone had evidence against these developers. He had documentation, witnesses, city records. He didn’t need to kill anyone. He had the filing cabinet the defense mentioned.”

The heavysset man pointed at Dan. “That’s the thing. The prosecution never explained why Boone would throw away the stronger hand.”

The holdout hadn’t moved. He was watching Dan with the same attention he’d given the witness stand all week: steady, patient, taking inventory.

“Hands and knees in a parking lot,” he said. “You talk like you’ve picked up brass. Where does a history professor learn that?”

The room turned. Dan felt it the way you feel a draft: eleven faces, and one of them doing arithmetic.

“The Cold War,” Dan said. “Forty years of professionals cleaning up after themselves. I teach it twice a week.” He shrugged. “Also television.”

Somebody laughed, Burris loudest, and the room let it go. The holdout didn’t laugh. He held Dan’s eyes for one more second, wrote something in his notebook, and turned the page.

Dan leaned back and let the next voice have the floor. He’d come into the room as the professor in the ninth chair. He was leaving it as someone the holdout had written down.

“He had a temper,” the trades guy said. First words in twenty minutes. “The prosecutor showed the emails. He was aggressive.”

“He was persistent,” the woman near the far end said. “There’s a difference.”

“Not when you’re on the other side of it.”

The foreperson held up a hand. “We’re drifting into motive. Let’s finish the crime scene first.”

They finished the crime scene. Two more jurors spoke — the chain-link fence behind the lot, the dead light pole on the west side, the loading dock.

The picture that built itself in the room was of a location chosen for a purpose, not stumbled into during an argument.

The thin man took off his glasses, cleaned them on his tie, and put them back on. “I’ve been thinking about this since yesterday, and I don’t think the prosecution met the standard. I’m changing my vote to not guilty.”

The foreperson wrote it down.

The woman who’d murmured her vote yesterday — the one who’d looked at the window — waited until the foreperson’s pen stopped. “I’m changing mine too.”

“That puts us at nine to three,” the foreperson said. She looked at the remaining guilty votes without singling anyone out. “We’ll pick up with timeline and motive tomorrow morning.”

Burriss looked around the table with the mild confusion of a man who’d missed a turn somewhere. The trades guy was already standing, his chair pushed back, arms at his sides. He walked out.

The holdout capped his pen and placed it beside his notebook. He looked at the foreperson.

“Nine to three,” he said. Not conceding. Confirming. He closed the notebook and stood, and his posture hadn’t changed since he’d sat down that morning.

Dan gathered his things and waited for the room to clear. Nine to three. The soft votes had gone where he’d known they’d go, and the majority had done the work without him leading it. His one contribution had landed and someone else had carried it forward. Good. He wouldn’t be making another.

But the holdout’s answers were still standing. Panic. Crisis. People don’t optimize. Wrong, every one of them, but built on a framework that didn’t need Dan’s particular knowledge to sound right. It needed Dan’s particular knowledge to sound wrong.

He walked out of the jury room ninth, same as yesterday. The hallway was bright and empty, and somewhere on the other side of the courthouse a

man was sitting in a plastic chair waiting to find out if he'd get his life back, and Dan couldn't help him from where he stood.

Chapter 19 — The Other Professional

Dan skipped the Thai place and went straight home. He wasn't hungry. He climbed the stairs to the third floor, dropped his keys on the counter, and got a beer from the refrigerator. The apartment was warm — he'd left the windows closed and the evening heat had settled in, thick and patient. The prepaid phone was in the drawer by the coffee filters. No missed calls, no messages. The broker was waiting for a verdict.

Most of the other tenants were still out or not home from work yet. The hum of the refrigerator and the muffled thump of a car door closing on the street below. Dan stood at the counter and drank the beer and thought about the jury room.

Nine to three. His argument had worked — the dumpster contradiction, the filing cabinet line, the question about why Boone would go to a parking lot behind a strip mall when he had evidence and documentation and witnesses willing to testify for him. The thin man had changed his vote. The window woman followed. The room was pulling toward acquittal, momentum doing the work that any single argument couldn't.

But the holdout was still there. Calm, organized, answering every point with something reasonable. And the trades guy was getting quieter, which in Dan's experience meant he was digging in, not coming around.

Dan finished the beer, rinsed the bottle, and set it by the sink. He could hear someone's television through the floor now — a laugh track, faint and rhythmic, the sounds of someone else's evening.

The dumpster.

He'd framed it as contradiction in the jury room. A shooter careful enough to collect his shell casings but reckless enough to dump a traceable weapon forty yards from the body. Two incompatible behaviors from the same person in the same three minutes. It worked because it was easy to understand and hard to answer. The thin man had been nodding before Dan finished.

But standing alone in his kitchen, Dan followed the logic one step further than he could have followed it in front of eleven other people.

It wasn't contradiction. It was two different intentions.

The casings were collected because the shooter was a professional. Reflex — you always picked up your brass. Dan had done it on every job he'd ever worked, even the ones where it didn't matter, even when the scene would be sanitized afterward. You did it because that was what you did. Muscle memory, deeper than planning, a habit that survived any set of instructions because it lived in your hands, not your head.

And the gun was left because it was supposed to be found.

Not panic. Not a first-time killer throwing evidence away in shock. A hired man following a script that required sloppiness he couldn't quite commit to. Pick up the brass because you can't help it. Leave the nine-millimeter in the dumpster because that's what you were told to do. The gun was the frame. The casings were the man underneath.

Dan got a second beer from the refrigerator and didn't open it. He held it against the counter and let the rest come.

The gun was stolen from Travis's nightstand while Travis was in Murfreesboro visiting his parents. Someone had found the bungalow on Fatherland Street, found the back door with its cheap lock, walked in, taken the nine-millimeter, and walked out. Travis didn't know it was gone until the detective told him about the ballistics match. Travis hadn't been careless. Someone else had been thorough.

Kinsey was lured to the Dickerson Pike lot. Dan had driven past it — one way in, one way out, one working light pole on the east side, shadow pooling on the west near the dumpster and the loading dock. A location chosen for its angles and its emptiness, not somewhere a land broker wandered into on a Tuesday night. Someone Kinsey knew — someone from the developer side — had told him to be there. And someone was waiting with Travis Boone's stolen gun.

Two shots, center mass, under ten feet. Professional distance, professional grouping. Then the brass collected off the asphalt out of habit, and the gun placed in the dumpster by instruction.

It was clean work. Not brilliant — Dan had seen better frames, and done cleaner work himself — but it didn't need to be brilliant. The detective who caught the case, Holmes, had done exactly what detectives did: found the gun in the dumpster, traced the serial, pulled the purchase record, checked Travis's public disputes with the victim, noted the range visits. A straight line from weapon to owner to motive to opportunity. Holmes had built his case from the front, and from the front it held together. It only fell apart when you walked around behind it, and Holmes had no reason to walk around behind it because the front looked solid.

Carsten Properties. The name on Defense Exhibit Four — the corporate filings the records clerk had authenticated while Caldwell sat there and didn't object. The same name on the construction banner at the development site on Music Row.

The man with the silver hair combed straight back. Fifties, heavy through the middle, gray suit. Dan had seen the Escalade twice at the site during surveillance, and the man beside it once — talking on his phone with the easy calm of a man whose problems were handled by other people. Dan hadn't been watching him. Dan had been mapping Travis — routes, routines, windows of vulnerability. The developer was background. Scenery. A heavy man beside a heavy vehicle, talking to someone about something that wasn't Dan's concern.

The chain ran straight. Developer boss, through whoever handled his problems, to broker to Dan. The same people who'd hired Dan to kill Travis Boone had framed Travis Boone for a murder they'd committed. The order gave it away. Dan had been hired first: the call came on a Tuesday, and the gun didn't leave Travis's nightstand until the Sunday after. Somewhere in that week Kinsey had become a problem too. Dan couldn't see why yet, but he could see the answer someone had found for it: kill the land broker with the commissioner's gun, and two problems go away in one night. Nobody had called Dan off. They'd put him on hold, and the broker had told him why on that Saturday call: *If the state convicts him, the problem's solved. If he walks, you finish the job.* If the frame stuck, Travis went to prison and the development moved forward. If the frame fell apart, Dan would be there to finish it.

Belt and suspenders. And Dan was the suspenders.

He set the unopened beer on the counter. The client would hire someone else. Different broker, maybe, different city for the next contractor, but the same outcome — as long as the man with the Escalade had a reason and a phone, Travis Boone was a line item waiting to be reassigned.

The development site. Dan had driven past three times — twice in daylight during surveillance, once at night the first week of the trial. The construction fence ran along the street. Behind it, vacant lots screened from the neighboring buildings by a row of oaks that hadn't been cleared yet. The Escalade had been there both daytime visits, parked near the south corner, same spot. The one time Dan had seen the man himself, it was late afternoon — pushing five, end of a workday, standing by the car like he'd just come out of one of the old buildings. Regular hours, probably, because his business was mostly legitimate and killing was something he outsourced.

Dan knew the approach from the east. He knew the sight lines from the adjacent street — what was visible, what wasn't, what a man standing by a car at that hour could and couldn't see coming. He knew the block went quiet after six when the neighboring businesses closed. He'd noted all of it during surveillance, automatically, out of habit — you mapped the whole environment, not just the target, because the environment was where the work got done.

He hadn't been mapping the developer. He'd been mapping Travis. But a map was a map, and the information didn't care why you'd collected it.

He didn't have the client's name yet. Just the silver hair and the gray suit and the Escalade and Carsten Properties on a courthouse exhibit. He didn't have a home address or a daily schedule beyond those two late afternoons at the site. But he had a face and a car and a building, and that was more than he'd started with on most jobs.

Dan walked to the living room window and looked out at Hillsboro Village. The bookstore was closed, its awning dark. The pub across the street had a few people still inside, and someone stood outside with a cigarette, its tip brightening and fading. A car passed below, headlights sweeping the oak

out front. Everything looked the same as any other night he'd stood at this window.

He stood there for a while. Then he turned from the window and walked down the hall toward the bedroom, but stopped at the spare bedroom door.

It was locked — always locked, a deadbolt he'd installed himself, the only modification he'd made to the apartment in three years. He reached up to the door frame and took down the key. The deadbolt turned smooth — he kept it oiled, checked it every few months whether he was working or not.

The room was small and plain. A desk against the wall, a corkboard above it with nothing pinned to it — he cleared it between jobs. A prepaid phone still in its packaging. A set of Tennessee plates in a manila envelope. A foam-lined case on the desk, closed. A notebook, empty — he used a new one each time and burned the old one when the work was done.

Dan stood in the doorway and took inventory without deciding to. What was there. What would need replacing. What came next.

He closed the door, locked it, and put the key back on the frame. Then he turned off the hall light and went to sleep.

Chapter 20 — Two Tracks

Friday the foreperson opened her notebook at nine and said “Timeline” like she was calling a meeting to order, which she was. The holdout had his pen ready. The trades guy sat with his arms crossed.

For an hour they went through what they’d already been through. Kinsey last confirmed alive at 8:17 PM — a phone call from a prepaid number nobody had traced, the last one on his records. Body found at 6:42 the next morning by the tax preparer opening her shop. Travis Boone said he was home alone that evening. No alibi, no phone calls after seven, nobody who could place him anywhere but his bungalow on Fatherland Street.

The holdout laid it out cleanly. A window of opportunity that fit the defendant. Proximity — Travis lived less than twenty minutes from the Dickerson Pike lot. Means — the gun was his, bought in his name. Motive — documented disputes, on the public record. He presented it in order, and when he finished he set his pen down and waited.

The not-guilty majority answered. No alibi wasn’t evidence. Half the city was home alone on a Tuesday night. The detective had locked onto Travis and never looked sideways. But they’d made these arguments yesterday, and the day before, and the holdout’s answers hadn’t changed, and the arguments weren’t going to change the answers.

Dan listened and said nothing.

Burris cleared his throat during a pause in the motive discussion. He’d been quiet all morning — no confused analogies, no contributions that needed redirecting.

“I’ve been thinking about it overnight,” he said. “And the gun thing. The dumpster.” He looked around the table as if someone might help him finish the thought. Nobody did. “I’m changing my vote. Not guilty.”

The foreperson wrote it down without looking up. “Ten to two.”

Nobody reacted. The holdout noted the count the same way he’d noted nine to three, and seven to five before that. The trades guy stared at Burris, then looked away.

The foreperson tried to push forward — the emails, Travis’s public statements at council meetings, whether the documented disputes amounted to motive. The holdout had a framework for each. The trades guy spoke twice, both times about what planning commissioners did to people rather than what this one had done to Kinsey. The foreperson redirected him both times. By noon the room was saying things it had already said, and everyone in it knew it.

The foreperson called a break.

Dan walked into the hallway, past the restrooms, past the vending machines, to a stretch of corridor where nobody was standing. He took out his university phone — the prepaid was at home in the drawer, same as every trial day — and scrolled to a number he hadn’t called since the previous fall.

Pat Holliday answered on the third ring. “Well.”

“I’ve got something in your line,” Dan said. “Buy you a drink at four?”

“Where?”

“Smitty’s.”

“See you there.”

Twelve seconds. Dan put the phone away and walked back.

They went another hour after the break. The foreperson made one more pass at the timeline — the gap between 8:17 and 6:42, the absence of any other suspect placed near the scene. The holdout restated his position. The trades guy hadn’t moved, jaw set. Nothing moved. The foreperson closed her notebook at one-thirty and told the room they’d pick up Monday morning.

Dan walked to the garage and got the Volvo.

Smitty’s was on a side street off Demonbreun — dark wood, a long bar, neon beer signs in the windows, a row of booths along the far wall. At four in the afternoon the place was nearly empty. A bartender, two men at the far

end watching a baseball game on the muted television, a woman in a booth with a laptop and a glass of wine. Dan took a stool near the middle and ordered a bourbon, neat.

Pat Holliday came through the door ten minutes later. Wiry and easygoing — mid-forties, dark hair thinning at the crown, two days of stubble that looked permanent rather than neglected. He wore a broken-in jacket over a flannel shirt, jeans, and boots that had logged more miles on pavement than trail. He took the stool next to Dan without greeting, caught the bartender's eye, and pointed at Dan's glass.

"Dan."

"Pat."

The bartender set the second bourbon down and moved to the far end. Pat picked up his glass, took a short sip, and set it down precisely where it had been. He watched the baseball game for a moment — someone grounding into a double play, the replay nobody asked for.

"You following the Boone trial?" Dan said.

"The planning commissioner. Shot a guy, they say."

"They say." Dan turned his glass on the bar. "The jury's deliberating. I know some people who've been watching it closely. There's a piece that hasn't come out yet."

Pat turned slightly on his stool. Listening now, not just sitting.

"Development company called Carsten Properties," Dan said. "They're behind the project Boone was blocking — Harmony Ridge, over on Music Row. The victim, Kinsey, was contracted to Carsten. Engagement letter, fee structure, ongoing business relationship. That's in the public filings, if you pull them."

"So far that's just business."

"It is. But Kinsey and the developer had a relationship that goes deeper than what came out at trial. I'd want to know who at Carsten was making decisions about the Boone problem — who stood to lose the most if the development stalled. And I'd want to know whether Kinsey was getting

nervous about the arrangement. Whether he was thinking about pulling back.”

“Someone getting cold feet.”

“Someone who maybe knew enough to be a liability.”

“Two problems for the same people,” Pat said.

“That’s the shape of it.”

Neither of them spoke. The baseball game cut to a commercial — a truck ad, then insurance.

“And you want this looked at,” Pat said.

“The parents want it looked at. Travis Boone’s mother and father. They put their house up for the defense and spent two weeks in the back row of a courtroom watching their son get tried for murder. When the verdict comes in — however it comes in — they’re going to want somebody looking at who actually did this.”

“They called you?”

“They don’t know I exist. You approach them cold. A concerned citizen heard about the case and thinks it deserves a fresh look. Someone’s willing to cover the investigator’s expenses.”

Pat looked at him.

“If they say they can’t afford it,” Dan said, “you tell them it’s already taken care of. They’ll figure it came through the defense attorney’s office — part of the retainer they paid. Nobody needs to sort out the funding.”

“Clean.”

“Clean enough.”

Pat picked up his drink. “How much of this do you already know?”

“Enough to know you’ll find what you’re looking for.”

“That’s not what I asked.”

“It’s what I’m telling you.”

Pat held his gaze for a beat, then set the glass down. His shoulders settled, one hand resting flat on the bar. He'd been here before — not this bar, but this exact conversation, with this exact amount of space between what was said and what wasn't.

"Timeline?" he said.

"Sooner rather than later. Verdict could come any day."

"Retainer?"

"Tomorrow. Cash."

Pat nodded. He finished his drink, set it on the bar, and stood up. "I'll start tonight. Corporate filings — I can pull those from home."

"Good."

Pat tapped the bar once, then walked out. The door let in a stripe of afternoon light and closed behind him.

Dan sat with his glass. The bartender was drying something at the far end. The baseball game was back — a pitcher working through his signs, the catcher settling, the stadium full of people who'd paid to watch someone else make decisions.

Two tracks running now. Pat would pull the filings, find the connections, build something a defense attorney could hand to a DA. Clean, legitimate, documented.

The other track had a foam-lined case and a set of Tennessee plates and a notebook with nothing written in it yet. That track was Dan's alone.

He finished his bourbon, left cash on the bar, and walked out into the late afternoon.

Chapter 21 — The Odds

His mother was already through the door before Travis had it all the way open, a white paper bag in each hand, his father a step behind carrying a drink tray with three sweating cups. She set the bags on the kitchen counter and started pulling out containers — fried chicken, coleslaw, biscuits in wax paper, a Styrofoam cup of gravy she'd asked for on the side.

"Sit down," she said, though Travis was already standing there. "Your father wanted Popeyes but the line was out to the street, so we went to that place on Gallatin."

"It's fine, Mom."

"I didn't say it wasn't fine. I said your father wanted Popeyes." She opened the containers and arranged them with the efficiency of someone setting a table she'd set ten thousand times. His father put the drinks down and took a stool. He hadn't mentioned Popeyes.

Travis pulled out the third stool and sat. His mother handed him a plate — not one of his plates, one she'd brought, still in the plastic sleeve from the dollar store. She'd thought of plates and he hadn't. He hadn't thought about eating at all.

"Your screen door sticks a little," his father said.

"I know."

"I can look at it."

"It's fine, Dad. It's the humidity."

His father nodded and opened a biscuit. His mother was already eating, standing at the counter because that's how she ate at home too — in motion, fork in one hand, napkin in the other, watching everyone else's plate more than her own.

They talked about the garden. His mother's tomato cages had blown sideways in a storm two nights ago, and his father had straightened them but the soil was still soft and she wasn't sure they'd hold. Travis listened and ate the chicken and let the bungalow fill with the sound of his parents' voices. His father mentioned a water heater — someone on their road in

Murfreesboro needed one replaced and had asked if he knew anybody. Travis said he didn't. His mother said the Hendersons' dog had gotten loose again and ended up in the Dollar General parking lot and Patty Henderson had to go get it in her bathrobe.

None of it mattered. All of it helped.

His mother ate one piece of chicken and a biscuit and put the rest of the containers in his refrigerator without asking if he wanted them put away. She rearranged what was already in there — a leftover pasta from two nights ago, a carton of eggs, a jar of pickles — to make room, and Travis let her because she needed to do it more than he needed to stop her.

Thirty minutes. Maybe less. His father finished eating and wiped his hands on a paper towel, and his mother started collecting the trash, and Travis could feel the visit reaching its natural end — the point where staying would mean acknowledging why they'd come, and leaving let it stay unspoken.

"We should get on the road," his mother said. "Your father doesn't like driving 24 in the dark."

His father didn't confirm or deny this. He stood and put his hand on Travis's shoulder — the same hand, the same shoulder, the same pressure as every other time they'd said goodbye since this started. Travis walked them to the door.

His mother stopped on the porch. "Eat that chicken tomorrow. Don't just let it sit in there."

"I will."

"And your porch light is out."

"I know."

She touched his arm, quick and firm, and went down the steps. His father followed. Travis stood at the screen door — the one that stuck — and watched the F-150 back out of the short driveway and turn toward the road. His mother's hand went up once through the passenger window as they pulled away. Then the taillights turned the corner and the street was quiet.

Travis closed the door and stood in the kitchen. The counter was clean — his mother had wiped it — and the trash was in the bag by the door, tied off. The bungalow was warm and smelled like fried chicken and his parents' familiar mix of soap and coffee and whatever his mother used on her hair. In ten minutes it would just smell like his house again.

He washed the plate she'd brought and set it in the drying rack. Wiped it down a second time for no reason. Walked to the living room and sat in the chair by the window and looked at the street where nothing was happening.

Three days. The jury had been out for three days.

His phone rang at seven-forty. Barr.

"How are you doing?" she said, which wasn't how she usually opened.

"I'm here."

"Jury went home again. They'll be back at nine Monday morning."

Travis looked at the ceiling. A hairline crack ran from the light fixture toward the corner, a crack he'd noticed the first week after his arrest and had been meaning to patch ever since. "Three days is a long time?"

"For a case this size, yes."

"What does that mean?"

She paused — not for effect, because Barr didn't do anything for effect. She was choosing her words. "It means they're having trouble reaching a unanimous verdict. If they report to the judge that they can't agree, he'll probably ask them to try again. If they still can't, he declares a mistrial."

"And then what?"

"The DA decides whether to retry. In my experience, with a split this late, they usually don't. The case goes away — not dismissed, not acquitted, but functionally over. Charges stay on the books but nobody moves on them."

"So I'd walk out."

"You'd walk out."

"But no verdict."

“No verdict.”

Travis sat with that. Outside, a car passed on Fatherland, its headlights sweeping across the front window and moving on. He could hear the neighbor’s air conditioner cycling on — a low mechanical hum that would run until October.

“What are the other options?” he said, though he already knew.

“They agree. Guilty or not guilty.”

Two out of three. He’d spent months imagining the worst — a conviction, sentencing, appeals, his parents visiting him somewhere with plastic chairs and vending machines. And now Barr was telling him that even the middle outcome, the one that wasn’t winning, was still walking out. Two of the three doors led to the street.

“What do you think they’ll do?” he said.

“I don’t predict juries.”

“Off the record.”

Another pause. “Three days means somebody’s holding out. Could be either side. If it’s one or two for guilty, they may come around. If it’s a block, we’re looking at a mistrial.” She said the next part plainly. “Either way, Travis, you’re in a better position tonight than you were at the start of the week.”

He thanked her and hung up. His parents’ visit was already fading into the silence of the house, the smell of chicken thinning out, the wiped counter the only evidence they’d been there. He sat in the chair and did the math again. Two out of three.

The nightstand drawer in the bedroom was empty. Same as last night, and the night before that, and every night since the detective told him about the ballistics match and he understood that someone had come into his home and taken his gun while he was in Murfreesboro eating his mother’s pot roast. He didn’t go check it. He knew what was in it.

He turned off the living room light and sat in the dark for a while, looking at the street. Two out of three. Tomorrow might be the last day he had to sit in a hallway and wait for twelve strangers to decide whether he was a

murderer. Or it might not be. But the math was better than it had been, and for the first time in months Travis Boone let himself think about what came after.

Dan was reading on the couch when the prepaid buzzed in the kitchen drawer. He set the book down and walked to the counter. One message, no name — the broker's number, committed to memory, never saved.

Just staying in touch.

Dan typed two words and hit send.

Still here.

He put the phone back in the drawer, next to the coffee filters, and closed it. Then he picked up his book and went back to the couch.

Chapter 22 — Mistril

Monday the foreperson opened her notebook at nine and closed it at nine-forty. In between, the holdout made his case one final time — means, motive, opportunity, the absence of another suspect — and nobody at the table had anything left to say to it. The trades guy hadn't spoken at all. He sat with his arms folded against his chest and looked at the wall behind the foreperson's head.

"I'm going to ask the room a question," the foreperson said. She took off her glasses and set them on the table. "Does anyone here believe that further deliberation will change their vote?"

Nobody answered. The holdout looked around the table, made a count he already knew, and shook his head once. The trades guy didn't move.

"All right," the foreperson said. She put her glasses back on and stood up. "I'll inform the judge."

She wrote a note on a sheet from her notebook, folded it, and knocked on the door. The bailiff opened it. She handed him the note without a word, and the door closed again. The foreperson sat back down. The room waited.

Twenty minutes. Someone poured coffee. Burris unwrapped a granola bar from the counter and ate it slowly, chewing with a patience that suggested he thought the delay might be about lunch. The holdout had his pen parallel to his notebook, both hands flat on the table. Dan sat in his chair and watched the side street through the tall windows. A delivery truck was double-parked below, its flashers pulsing orange against the building across the way.

The bailiff came back and told them the judge was ready.

They filed into the courtroom single file. Dan was ninth through the door, same as the first time, and took his seat in the jury box. The courtroom had reassembled — Caldwell at the prosecution table with his legal pad and file boxes, squared and ready. Barr at the defense table, straight-backed, pen in hand. Travis beside her in a blue shirt, the same shirt or one like it — Dan couldn't tell and it didn't matter. Travis's parents were in the back row. His

mother was leaning forward with her hands clasped. His father sat upright and still.

The judge looked at the foreperson.

"Madam Foreperson, has the jury reached a unanimous verdict?"

"We have not, Your Honor."

"Is it the jury's belief that further deliberation would be productive?"

The foreperson glanced at the room she'd managed for four days. "No, Your Honor. We've discussed the evidence thoroughly and our positions are firm."

The judge nodded. He removed his glasses, cleaned them with a cloth he kept near the bench, and put them back on. Thirty years of this and he still had a routine for the hard ones.

"I'm going to ask you to deliberate once more," he said. He spoke to the whole box, evenly, leaning on nothing. "Return to the jury room. Re-examine your own views. Listen to one another with an open mind. No juror should surrender an honest conviction solely to return a verdict. But if a verdict can be reached in good conscience, the parties and the public are entitled to one. Take whatever time you need."

They filed back down the short hallway. Nobody spoke. In the jury room, nobody reached for the coffee.

The foreperson sat down and folded her hands on her notebook. "You heard him. Does anyone want to say anything they haven't already said?"

The holdout was quiet for a moment, and Dan watched him actually do it — re-examine, as the judge had asked, with the same care he'd brought to his own work his entire life. Then he looked up. "My view of the evidence hasn't changed. Guilty." Level as ever. No heat in it.

"Guilty," the trades guy said, harder, with something underneath that wasn't about evidence.

The foreperson went around the table one last time anyway, for the record she'd been keeping since the first afternoon. Ten not guilty. Dan said his

without elaboration. Burris said “Not guilty” clearly and without hesitation, as though he’d held the position all along and couldn’t imagine why anyone would ask.

“Ten to two,” the foreperson said. “Same ten. Same two.” She wrote the second note, and this time the room watched her fold it.

Forty minutes after they’d left it, they were back in the jury box. The judge looked at the foreperson.

“Madam Foreperson, has further deliberation changed the jury’s position?”

“No, Your Honor. It has not.”

“Is it your belief that additional deliberation would produce a unanimous verdict?”

“No, Your Honor.”

The judge didn’t ask how they were divided, and he didn’t look at the jury when he spoke. The courtroom was still — the particular stillness of a room that has arrived somewhere without resolution. “The court finds that this jury is unable to reach a unanimous verdict. I am declaring a mistrial in the matter of the State of Tennessee versus Travis Boone.”

He thanked the jurors for their service. He said something about civic duty and the difficulty of the task and the importance of the process. Dan heard the words without holding them — standard language, delivered with enough sincerity to be decent and enough practice to be brief. The judge dismissed the jury.

Dan stood with the others. From the jury box he could see the defense table — Barr had a hand on Travis’s forearm, leaning in, speaking close to his ear. Travis was looking at the table. His parents hadn’t moved from the back row. Across the aisle, Caldwell was placing his legal pad into the first file box, his movements precise and deliberate. A man packing up a case he’d expected to win.

Dan filed out with the other jurors through the side door. In the hallway, someone said something about parking validation. The foreperson walked past, already gone. Burris looked around as if expecting someone to explain

what happened next. The holdout walked toward the elevator, alone, at the same measured pace he'd maintained all week. At the call button he turned his head and found Dan down the hall, and looked at him for a moment the way he'd looked at the table on Thursday, taking inventory. Then the doors opened and he stepped in.

Dan turned the other way, toward the stairs. As he passed the courtroom's main doors, they opened. Barr came out first, her briefcase in one hand, already on her phone. Behind her, Travis stepped into the hallway with his parents on either side — his mother's hand through his arm, his father a half-step behind, the three of them moving together the way families move through hospital corridors, not quite sure which direction leads out.

Travis stopped near the window at the end of the hall. Barr finished her call and turned back to him. Dan was fifteen feet away, walking, not slowing down.

"I know what he's going to decide," Barr said. Her voice carried in the empty corridor — not loud, just undampened. "But I'll call you when it's official."

Travis nodded. Barr touched his shoulder once, briefly, and headed for the elevator bank.

Dan kept moving. He was almost to the stairwell door when he heard Travis behind him, on the phone, his voice lighter than Dan had heard it in two weeks of sitting across a courtroom from him.

"Hey, Mom — yeah, I know you're right there. Listen, I've got some leftover chicken at my place if you and Dad want to come over."

Dan pushed through the stairwell door and took the stairs down to the garage. The Volvo was where he'd left it, second level, near the elevator. He started the engine and pulled out into the afternoon. The courthouse shrank in the rearview mirror and then he turned onto Second Avenue and it was gone.

Chapter 23 — Three Calls

That afternoon Dan dropped his keys on the kitchen counter and stood in the apartment without turning on a light. Late afternoon sun came through the living room window, throwing a long rectangle across the floor and up the far wall. Someone's dog barked once, two floors down, and stopped.

He opened the drawer by the coffee filters and took out the prepaid. One missed call — the broker, forty minutes ago. No message. Dan looked at the number and set it on the counter. He got a glass of water from the tap, drank half of it, and set it beside the phone.

He picked it up and called back.

The broker answered on the second ring. "Heard your boy walked."

"Hung jury," Dan said.

"So he's out."

"He's out. But the pattern's different now. His mother was at the courthouse — I heard her telling him he should come stay with them in Murfreesboro for a few days. Recuperate. I don't know if he'll go, but if he does, that's forty-five minutes from his regular address and a house I haven't mapped."

What Dan had actually heard was Travis offering his parents leftover chicken. But the broker had no one inside that hallway, and a worried mother was the kind of detail nobody questioned.

"How long?"

"Give me a week. If he stays in Nashville, I pick up his routine and we're back on track. If he goes to the parents' place, I need to drive down there and see what the property looks like. Either way, I need to know where he's sleeping before I move."

Silence on the line. The broker processing — not suspicious, just calculating. Dan could hear him breathing, a faint electronic hiss behind it.

"The client," Dan said. "He understand this takes what it takes? I don't want calls every two days asking why it isn't done."

"I'll manage him. You manage the work."

“That’s what I’m doing.”

“Week,” the broker said. “Then I want to hear something.”

“You will.”

The line went dead. Dan put the prepaid back in the drawer and closed it. The glass of water was still on the counter, half full, catching the last of the afternoon light.

He stood at the counter and looked at what he’d just done. He had lied to a client to keep a target alive, the first lie of his working life told against the job instead of for it. The week wasn’t for finding out where Travis Boone slept. It was for the man with the silver hair, whoever he turned out to be. Nobody would pay for that one, and nobody had asked. He was going to do it anyway.

He sat on the couch and picked up his university phone. Scrolled to Pat Holliday’s number.

Pat answered on the first ring this time. “I was going to call you.”

“Go ahead.”

“Carsten Properties — sole principal is a man named Victor Ruhl. Incorporated in Tennessee, 2016. Kinsey’s engagement letter names Ruhl directly. Fee structure’s got him on retainer going back eighteen months. There’s a lawyer on the corporate filings too — Raymond Voss, registered agent, office on West End.”

Dan held the names. Ruhl. Voss. The silver hair and the gray suit had a name now, and so did the lawyer on the filings.

“The parents,” Dan said. “When are you going to them?”

“Tomorrow or the day after. The verdict just came in — I’ll give it a beat. Concerned citizen reaches out too fast, it looks staged.”

“Good.”

“How’s your end?”

“Moving.”

Pat didn't ask what that meant. He said he'd call after the parents, and hung up.

Dan set the phone down on the couch cushion. The apartment was getting dark — the rectangle of sun had climbed the wall and disappeared. He sat there for a minute, then stood and walked down the hall.

The spare bedroom key was on the door frame where it always was. He reached up, turned the deadbolt, and pushed the door open. The room smelled like nothing — no air freshener, no dust, just still air in a closed space. The desk was against the wall, the corkboard empty above it. The foam case sat where he'd left it, closed. The packaged prepaid phone. The manila envelope with the plates.

Dan pulled the chair out and sat down. He opened the desk drawer and took out the notebook — the empty one, new for this job, the same kind he always used. A cheap composition book, black cover, college-ruled. He uncapped a pen and wrote.

Victor Ruhl. Carsten Properties. Harmony Ridge Development, Music Row.

Black Cadillac Escalade. Silver hair combed back, heavy build, gray suit. 50s.

Development site — south corner. Escalade parked same spot both visits. Man seen once, late afternoon, by the car. Hours look regular — confirm.

Sight lines from east approach. Adjacent street — businesses close after 6. Block goes quiet.

Need: home address, daily schedule, full name confirmation. Voss connection — leverage or liability?

He looked at what he'd written. It was thin. Five lines on a man he'd seen twice and hadn't been watching. But he'd been in the same space, breathing the same air, noting the same angles — just for a different reason. The information was there. It just needed pointing in a new direction.

The Glock was in the foam case, three feet from his right hand. Nine-millimeter, suppressed, clean. The weapon he'd carried on every job for the last four years. He didn't open the case.

He turned to a fresh page and wrote one line.

20-gauge. Pump. Not mine.

The packaged prepaid was on the desk where it had sat since the last job. Dan cut the plastic with his thumbnail, powered it on, and waited for a signal. When it came, he dialed a number from memory. A 615 area code, a man he'd bought from twice before, both times clean.

Three rings. "Yeah."

"It's Dan. I need a twenty-gauge pump. Used is fine. Nothing pretty."

"When?"

"Two days."

"Same place?"

"Same place. Cash."

"I'll have something."

The call lasted twenty seconds. Dan set the prepaid on the desk — operational now, one more phone in rotation — and looked at the notebook. Two pages. Victor Ruhl on one, the weapon on the other. The Glock in its case, untouched. The twenty-gauge would arrive in two days from a man whose last name Dan had never asked for, and it would be used once, wiped, and gone by the end of the night.

He closed the notebook and put the pen down. Three calls — the broker, Pat, the arms man. Three conversations in three different registers, and the only person who knew what all three meant was sitting alone in a room the size of a walk-in closet with a deadbolt on the door.

Dan turned off the light and locked the room behind him. He put the key back on the frame and went to the kitchen to figure out dinner.

Chapter 24 — Fieldwork

Wednesday morning, at a public terminal on the second floor of the downtown library, Dan typed Victor Ruhl's name. Carsten Properties had a website the way every developer did: renderings of buildings that didn't exist yet, and a page called *Leadership* with one photograph on it. Silver hair combed straight back, a heavy face arranged into something meant to look like vision. The man beside the Escalade. Dan cleared the history, logged off, and walked out past the periodicals.

That afternoon Dan parked the Volvo on the adjacent street at three-fifteen and cut the engine. From here he could see the south end of the development site through the gap between a guitar repair shop and a vacant storefront with brown paper taped over the windows. The construction fence ran along the front with its banner — HARMONY RIDGE DEVELOPMENT — A PREMIER MIXED-USE COMMUNITY — the vinyl starting to curl at the corners where the grommets had pulled loose. Behind the fence, three old buildings sat in a row. No construction equipment. No workers. Whatever Carsten Properties was building here, they hadn't started tearing down what was already there.

The black Escalade was parked at the south corner, same spot as the last two times Dan had seen it. Back when he'd been watching Travis.

He adjusted his seat back two inches and settled in. The guitar shop was still open — a kid behind the counter, visible through the front window, doing something on his phone. The vacant storefront was dark. Across the street, a print shop had a CLOSED sign but the lights were on inside. A woman came out carrying a box, locked the door behind her, and drove away in a Honda. By four o'clock the block would be down to the guitar kid and whatever foot traffic drifted through on the way to somewhere else.

Dan watched the development site. The building Ruhl used as an office — if that's what it was — sat at the near end of the row. Two stories, brown brick, a metal door on the side that faced the parking area. No signage. The windows on the second floor were dark. Ruhl went in through the side door and came out through the side door, and the Escalade was always waiting when he did.

The sight lines from the east were clean. The adjacent street where Dan was parked ran parallel to the site, one block over, with the guitar shop and the vacant storefront between him and the fence. If he came in on foot from this direction after six, the businesses would be closed. The block would be empty. The side door was forty yards from the gap between the buildings — visible, approachable, unlit after dark.

Dan noted it and kept watching.

At four-forty the side door opened and Ruhl came out — phone against his ear, talking, not looking around. Silver hair combed back, dark suit today instead of gray, the same heavy build. He walked to the Escalade with the unhurried stride of a man who owned the lot he was crossing, leaned in through the passenger door for something off the seat, and walked back to the building. The metal door swung shut behind him. The Escalade stayed in the corner.

Dan didn't wait for him to come out again. He had a pickup to make at five-fifteen, and Ruhl wasn't going anywhere — still at it mid-afternoon with no sign of wrapping up, the Escalade planted in the south corner like it lived there. The man once during the Travis surveillance, the Escalade vouching for the days in between, and now this. Ruhl worked late, and he worked alone. Tomorrow Dan would wait him out — see how late the man stayed, follow him home, learn the neighborhood and what the street looked like after dark.

He sat in the Volvo for another minute. The development site was still. The metal door was closed, the Escalade in the corner, the guitar kid behind the counter on his phone.

The building at the far end of the row was smaller than the other two. Single story, flat roof, a faded sign above the door that Dan couldn't read from this distance. He'd driven past it in April without looking twice — it was background then, part of the scenery around Travis's commute. He knew what it was now. The building where James Wardell had built a recording studio out of a former barbershop. Two rooms — a live space with concrete floors and a four-track board assembled from catalogue parts. Roosevelt Hayes had played bass there. Bobby Elam had cut his first album in a room

not much bigger than Dan's living room. Marian Telford had stood at a microphone in that building and recorded the voice that would sing at the March on Washington.

Students from Fisk and Tennessee State had sat in that same room and planned how to walk into a lunch counter and not leave.

Dan looked at the building. He was fifty yards from it, parked on a side street in a ten-year-old Volvo, and he had been sitting here for an hour cataloguing angles and exit times for a man he intended to kill in its shadow. The dissertation was on his desk at home, dog-eared to the Nashville section. Page 174, the footnote on Crown Recording. He'd ordered it two weeks before the Boone contract came in, because he was interested, because the history was worth knowing, because that was the part of his life that wasn't manufactured.

He sat with it for a few seconds longer than he should have. Then he started the car.

The parking lot was behind a carpet warehouse on Nolensville Pike, half a mile past the last strip mall that was still in business. Dan pulled in at five-fifteen. A gray pickup was already there, backed into the far corner near the dumpsters. Dan parked two spots over, driver's side facing driver's side, and left the engine running.

The man in the pickup reached across his cab and handed a canvas duffel through the window. Dan set it on his passenger seat and unzipped it. Remington 870, pump action, blued finish worn to silver at the edges. Stock scratched, action smooth. He cycled it once — clean, functional, nothing pretty.

Dan zipped the bag, reached into his jacket, and passed an envelope across. The man thumbled it without counting and dropped it on his seat.

"Anything else?"

"That's it."

Dan put the Volvo in gear and drove off. The duffel went in the trunk, under the roadside kit he kept behind the spare tire. The whole exchange had taken forty seconds.

Pat called at eight. Dan was in the kitchen, standing at the counter with a plate of pasta he'd made from whatever was in the cabinet. He picked up the university phone on the second ring.

"Talked to the parents today," Pat said. "Drove out to Murfreesboro."

"And?"

"Mother did most of the talking. Father sat there. They want it — they want someone looking. I told them I'd seen the trial coverage and the corporate filings that came out during testimony. Carsten Properties, the Kinsey connection. Told them there's more to pull on if someone pulls."

"What did they say?"

"Mother said yes before I finished the sentence. Father nodded. They're calling Travis tonight — he'll meet me tomorrow."

"Where?"

"His place. East Nashville. I told them I'd come to him."

Dan ate a forkful of pasta and set the fork down. "The corporate filings are public record now. Defense entered them as an exhibit. Start there — it's clean, it's on the record, and it gives you a legitimate reason to have been looking."

"Already pulled them," Pat said. "Carsten Properties, sole principal Victor Ruhl, registered agent Raymond Voss. I'll walk Travis through what's there and see what he can add from his end. Planning commissioner — he might know things about the development that aren't in the filings."

"He might."

"I'll call you after."

Dan hung up and finished the pasta. He washed the plate and the pot and set them in the rack. Through the living room window, the streetlight on the corner threw its usual circle on the sidewalk below. A couple walked through it and kept going.

The twenty-gauge was in the trunk of the Volvo, parked on the street. The Glock was in the spare bedroom, in its case, untouched. The notebook had two pages of entries and would have more tomorrow. Pat was meeting Travis tomorrow. The broker thought Dan was re-establishing a dead man's routine.

Dan turned off the kitchen light and went to the living room. The book he'd been reading was on the couch where he'd left it — not Gaddis, something else, a paperback he'd found at McKay's — and opened it to where he'd left off. He read for an hour without retaining much and went to bed.

Chapter 25 — Under a Cloud

Travis had cleaned the kitchen twice since Tuesday. He'd wiped down the counters, scrubbed the stovetop, taken everything out of the refrigerator and thrown away two containers he didn't open. He'd swept the porch and sorted the recycling and run a load of towels that didn't need washing. The bungalow was cleaner than it had been since he'd moved in, and it was nine in the morning and he had nothing left to do with his hands.

He made coffee and stood at the sliding door with the mug, looking out at the backyard. The grass needed cutting. He could do that. He could go to the hardware store and buy a new blade for the mower. That was most of an hour if he drove slow. He was still on the payroll — administrative leave, full pay, the kind of arrangement that sounded generous until you realized it meant no one wanted you back in the building. The leave lasted as long as the charges did, and the charges lasted until Caldwell decided whether to retry. Travis could call the office and ask if anyone had heard anything, but he already knew the answer would be a long pause followed by something about process and timelines, and he wasn't ready to hear it from someone who used to wave at him in the hallway.

The deadbolt on the back door caught the light from the window — brushed steel, heavy, the locksmith's best. Eleven hundred dollars. His mother had tried to pay for it and he'd said no, and then she'd left an envelope in the truck when he wasn't looking and he'd mailed it back. The old lock had been the kind you could open with a credit card, and someone had, and now a man was dead with Travis's gun and Travis was standing in his own kitchen trying to figure out what to do with a Thursday.

He took his coffee to the living room and opened the laptop on the couch. There was a Tennessean article from two days ago — HUNG JURY IN BOONE MURDER TRIAL; PROSECUTORS WEIGH RETRIAL — and he read it because he couldn't not. Four paragraphs of facts he'd lived through, rendered in the flat language of someone who'd been in the courtroom and understood none of it. The comments were worse. He read three of them and closed the laptop and set it on the floor by the couch.

His phone buzzed at ten-fifteen. Mom.

“Hey, baby. You eat breakfast?”

“I had coffee.”

“Coffee is not breakfast. There’s a casserole in your freezer, the one I brought Monday. You just put it at three-fifty for forty minutes.”

“I know how an oven works, Mom.”

“Three-fifty,” she said. “Forty minutes.”

“Your father’s going to Lowe’s this afternoon. He wants to know if you need anything for the house.”

Travis thought about the screen door that stuck when it rained and the porch light that had been out for a week. His father had noticed the one and his mother the other. “Tell him a can of WD-40 and a sixty-watt bulb for the porch.”

“You sleeping all right?”

“Yeah.”

She didn’t push it, which meant she knew. There was a pause — not the awkward kind, the kind where his mother was deciding whether to say the next thing or let it go. She let it go.

“You want to come down this weekend? I’m making pot roast Saturday. Your father said he’d clean the guest room.”

“Maybe. Let me see how the week goes.”

“Okay, baby. Call me if you need anything.”

He said he would and hung up. The call had lasted two minutes and twelve seconds — he saw it on the screen before it went dark. Longest conversation he’d had in three days.

Travis was on the porch by one-thirty, sitting in the chair by the railing with a glass of water and nothing else. He’d been there for an hour, watching the street the way he used to watch it before all of this — the neighbor’s cat

crossing the sidewalk, a delivery van, two kids on bikes. The bicycle was still locked to the railing next to him, the tires soft, the chain starting to rust. He hadn't ridden it since before the arrest.

The man who came up the porch steps was lean, medium height, with dark hair that was thinning on top and stubble that looked like it had been there for a while and would be there tomorrow. Broken-in jacket over a flannel shirt, jeans, boots that had seen pavement. He moved without hurrying — practiced, not lazy.

“Travis Boone?”

“Yeah.”

“Pat Holliday.” He didn't extend his hand — just stood at the top of the steps with his hands at his sides, giving Travis room. “I'm a private investigator. Licensed in Tennessee. Your parents asked me to come talk to you.”

Travis set his water down on the arm of the chair. “My parents.”

“I drove out to Murfreesboro yesterday. Your mother — she's been following the trial coverage. The corporate filings that came out during testimony, the Carsten Properties connection. She wanted to know if someone could look into it.”

“And you're that someone.”

“If you want me to be. I'm not here to sell you anything. I looked at the public record — the defense exhibits, the corporate filings, what's in the county assessor's office. There's a thread there. Carsten Properties, the Kinsey engagement, the development on Music Row. I think there's more to find if someone looks.”

Travis studied him. He'd spent weeks being handled — by Barr, by the judge, by a system that moved him from room to room on a schedule he didn't set. Everyone who'd stood in front of him since the arrest had wanted something specific: a plea, a statement, an answer to a question designed to produce a result. This man was standing on his porch asking for nothing except whether Travis wanted to talk.

“My parents can't afford a private investigator.”

“Your parents aren’t paying me,” Pat said. “I have another client whose interests overlap with yours. They’re covering my time. Your parents are how I got your name — that’s all.”

Travis waited for more. Pat didn’t offer any.

“Who’s the other client?”

“Someone who wants Carsten Properties looked at for their own reasons. That’s as much as I can give you.” Pat said it without apology. “Point is, nobody’s going into debt over this.”

Travis picked up his water and drank. He looked at the street — the neighbor’s cat was back, sitting in a patch of sun on the opposite sidewalk. He thought about Barr, who would tell him to call her before talking to anyone. He thought about the empty nightstand in the bedroom, the laptop on the floor, the casserole in the freezer. He thought about what it felt like to sit on this porch every day and wait for something that wasn’t coming.

“You want to come inside?”

Pat nodded once and followed him through the front door.

Travis led him to the kitchen table — the same table where he’d sat with Barr the week before the trial, going over testimony prep, and where his mother had sat across from him and talked about everything in the world except what was happening to her son. He pulled out a chair for Pat and got two glasses of water from the tap.

“What do you want to know?” Travis said.

“Start wherever you want. The development, the commission, Kinsey — wherever it makes sense to you.”

Travis sat down across from him. He hadn’t told the story from the beginning to anyone who wasn’t his lawyer. Barr had heard it in pieces, shaped by legal strategy, trimmed to what mattered in court. His parents had heard the version he could say without his mother crying. Nobody had asked him to just talk.

“The development came across my desk about two years ago,” Travis said. “Harmony Ridge. Mixed-use, Music Row corridor. Standard review —

zoning compliance, density, infrastructure impact. Nothing unusual until I pulled the historical records for the parcels.”

Pat took a small notebook from his jacket pocket and set it on the table, cover closed. He didn’t pick up a pen.

“There was a recording studio on one of those parcels,” Travis said. “Crown Recording. Operated in the late fifties and sixties. I found the original permits, a zoning variance from 1956 that listed the building as a recording studio. I started making calls.”

Pat listened. Travis kept going — the calls to university archives, the retired musician who’d recorded there, the neighborhood history project that led him to a woman who’d grown up three blocks away. He told Pat about the public meetings where he’d clashed with Kinsey, the emails, the formal review he’d filed. He told him about the phone call he’d overheard — Kinsey at the commission, nervous, talking about someone who wouldn’t listen.

“If I’d been convicted,” Travis said, “they’d have been done with both of us at once. Kinsey was the middleman who was getting cold feet. I was the commissioner who wouldn’t sign off. One man dead, the other in prison, and the development goes through without anyone left to ask questions about it.”

Pat opened his notebook for the first time and wrote something down.

Travis watched him write. He was sitting at his own kitchen table, telling the story he’d been carrying alone since the arrest to a man he’d met ten minutes ago. Someone was listening, and for the first time since the jury filed out of the courtroom, Travis Boone was doing something other than waiting.

Chapter 26 — Closing the Loop

Dan was back on the adjacent street by five, into the long tail of the afternoon. Same spot, same angle through the gap between the guitar shop and the vacant storefront. The Escalade was in the south corner. The vinyl banner had curled another inch since yesterday.

He shut the engine off and settled in. Ruhl worked late; this would take a while.

A little past six, with the shops dark and the block emptied out around him, the side door opened and Ruhl came out — phone, silver hair, dark suit, the same walk to the same vehicle. Third sighting of the man, same pattern. Dan gave him a thirty-second head start and followed.

The Escalade went west on the avenue, then south through midtown. Ruhl drove like he knew where he was going and had no reason to hurry. Dan stayed three cars back through the light at Broadway, then two on West End where the traffic thinned. Ruhl signaled every turn. He crossed into Belle Meade on Leake Avenue and turned left onto a residential street lined with oaks and stone walls.

The house was set back from the road behind a low iron fence — cream-colored stone, two stories, slate roof, a circular drive with a fountain that wasn't running. Mature landscaping on both sides. The neighbors were close enough to see the driveway from their second floors, and the street had good lighting — the even, maintained kind that came with association dues. Ruhl pulled through the gate and parked beside a white SUV already in the drive.

Dan kept going. He circled the block once — the backyard was fenced, high privacy hedge, another house twenty yards behind it with a clear sightline from the upper windows. A man walking through this neighborhood at night would draw attention. A car parked on the street for more than ten minutes would draw more.

He turned back toward the avenue and headed home.

He made eggs and toast and ate standing at the counter. The notebook was on the kitchen table. He sat down with a pen and added the address on the Belle Meade street, the route Ruhl took from the site, the white SUV in the drive — wife, or a housekeeper's car, or a guest. It didn't matter. The home was off the list.

He wrote underneath: *Site. After six, when the block empties. Weeknight. Side door approach from east — through gap between buildings, 40 yards. Departure same route.* Then he shut the notebook and rinsed his plate.

Pat called at eight-thirty.

"Met with Travis today," Pat said. "His place in East Nashville."

"How'd it go?"

"Kid talked for two hours. Once he got going he didn't want to stop. I don't think anyone's asked him to tell the whole story before — not without a legal strategy attached."

Dan leaned against the counter. "What'd he give you?"

"Most of it you'd expect. The review, the studio, the fights with Kinsey — all on the record, same as it came out at trial. And one thing that isn't." Pat paused. "Travis overheard Kinsey on the phone at the commission about eight or nine months before the murder. Kinsey didn't see him at first. Travis heard him say — and I'm quoting Travis here — 'Told him it's not worth the exposure. He doesn't listen. He never listens.'"

Dan didn't say anything.

"Travis said Kinsey looked up, saw him standing there, and walked away. Never mentioned it again. Travis didn't know who Kinsey was talking to, or about who. But the way he remembers it, Kinsey sounded worried. Not angry — worried."

"Who's 'he'?"

"Travis doesn't know. But if it's the principal — Ruhl — then you've got a middleman telling someone that the boss is taking too many risks. Eight months later the middleman is dead in a parking lot."

Dan picked up his glass of water and drank. Through the window over the sink, the streetlight lit its usual circle on the sidewalk below.

Kinsey had been trying to pull back. Whoever he'd been talking about — and the corporate filings made it clear enough who that was — hadn't listened. And then Kinsey was dead with two rounds in his chest behind a strip mall, and the gun that killed him had been stolen from the man who'd been causing problems at the planning commission.

Ruhl hadn't needed to pull any trigger himself. He just needed to make a phone call — the same kind of phone call that had eventually reached Dan's prepaid through the broker's chain.

Dan set the glass down.

"What about the defense attorney?" he said.

"I'm going to reach out to her this week. Barr — she represented Travis at trial. I want to walk her through what I've got. The corporate filings are already on the record from the trial, but the Kinsey call never came out. Barr knew about it and couldn't use it without putting Travis on the stand. Next to the filings, it's a different animal. Barr can decide whether to take it to the DA or sit on it."

"She'll take it."

"I think so too. It's the kind of thing that opens a second investigation — not just who killed Kinsey, but who hired it."

"Anything else?"

"One thing. Boone's driving down to his parents' place tomorrow afternoon — staying the weekend. His mother's been working on him since the verdict. He gave me the number down there in case anything moves."

"Good," Dan said.

Dan hung up. He rinsed the glass and left it in the sink. He could hear the building's pipes through the wall — someone running water two floors down.

He went to the kitchen table and opened the notebook. Below the home address and the site notes, he wrote: *Kinsey tried to walk. Client didn't listen. Middleman removed.* And on the line below that: *Boone — Murfreesboro, Fri afternoon through Sunday.* If Friday evening got loud, the first name anyone would reach for would be forty miles away at his mother's kitchen table, in front of witnesses. Then he closed the notebook.

Dan capped the pen and put it in the drawer. Tomorrow was Friday.

Chapter 27 — Friday

Dan parked on the adjacent street at four and checked the south corner of the lot. The Escalade was there.

He sat for a few minutes with the window down. The guitar shop was open, the kid visible behind the counter. A woman walked past on the sidewalk carrying grocery bags. Across the street, the print shop had its lights on. Normal afternoon, normal block.

Weeks ago there had been a packet on his kitchen table with a different name on it. A fee, a timeline, a man in a bind who wanted a problem solved. The man in the bind was in the building now, forty yards off, finishing his Friday. Dan had been hired to make one person go away so this man's arrangement could go forward, and the arrangement was what he'd come to take apart. He noted the shape of it — a fact about the job, neither here nor there — and moved past it.

He got out, went to the trunk, and took the canvas duffel from under the roadside kit. The Glock, the backup he never expected to need, went in his jacket pocket. He closed the trunk and walked.

Through the gap between the guitar shop and the vacant storefront. Across the open ground. Forty yards to the metal door on the side of the brown brick building. He didn't hurry. A man carrying a bag, walking toward a building on a Friday afternoon. The door had a lever handle, commercial grade. He pressed it and it gave.

Inside was a hallway — linoleum over concrete, drop ceiling with half the tiles missing, fluorescent fixtures that hadn't been lit in years. The air was stale and warm. To his left, a staircase going up. Straight ahead, the hallway ran past two closed doors toward the back of the building. Light came from under the second door. He could hear a voice — Ruhl, on the phone, the words indistinct through the wall.

Dan tried the first door. It opened into a storage room — filing boxes stacked against the walls, a metal shelving unit, a window painted shut. No second exit. He stepped inside, set the duffel on the floor, and unzipped it. He pulled on a pair of thin gloves. The Remington came out in two motions. He checked the action and held it along his leg.

He left the door open an inch and listened.

Ruhl's voice carried through the hallway in fragments. Numbers, a date, something about permits. The conversation had the quality of routine business — not wrapping up, not urgent. Dan stood in the storage room with the shotgun against his thigh and waited.

He had waited in rooms like this before, for other men, on other afternoons. The waiting was always the same — the stale air, the street thinning out, the target's voice going about its business on the far side of a wall. What was different this time was small and he only let himself look at it once. No one had sent him. There was no client on the far end of the broker's phone, no packet, no half up front. He'd built this one himself, and there was no one to bill for it and no one to answer to. He stood with the shotgun against his thigh and let the block go quiet.

The building settled around him. Through the painted window he could hear the block outside — a car door, the guitar shop's playlist bleeding faintly through the wall, a truck passing on the avenue. He listened to it thin out. The music stopped. A door closed somewhere down the street — the kid locking up. An engine started and faded. After that, nothing. The building's old pipes ticked once and stopped.

Ruhl was still on the phone. His voice had dropped to a murmur — listening more than talking now. Dan heard a chair creak and then the conversation ended. A drawer opened and closed. Footsteps — Ruhl moving around the room, heavy and slow.

Dan picked up the bag with his left hand and stepped into the hallway.

The second door was ajar. The room beyond it was larger than Dan expected — a front office converted into a workspace. Desk against the far wall, papers and a laptop, a floor lamp throwing warm light into the corner. Ruhl was standing behind the desk with his back to the door, putting something into a briefcase.

Dan came through the doorway and Ruhl turned at the sound. Silver hair, heavy face, the expression of a man interrupted by something he hadn't accounted for. He looked at Dan — a stranger, nobody, a face he'd never seen

— and then he looked at the shotgun. Somewhere behind a desk like the one at his back, months ago, this man had decided a problem was worth a man with a gun. He was looking at what he'd bought and he didn't recognize it, and there was no time to explain it to him.

Dan fired from eight feet.

The sound in the closed room was enormous. Ruhl went backward into the desk and then down. The laptop slid off the edge and hit the floor. The floor lamp rocked but didn't fall.

Dan pumped the action. The spent shell ejected and skittered across the linoleum. He left it where it landed. A professional picked up his brass, and this room was meant to look like the work of someone who wasn't one: an angry man with a secondhand shotgun who hadn't thought past the trigger. He'd loaded the shell with gloves on. It could lie there all it wanted. He stood for three seconds, watching. Then he put the Remington back in the duffel, zipped it, and walked out.

The hallway was the same. The stale air, the missing ceiling tiles, the lever handle on the side door. He pressed it open with his elbow. The lot was empty except for the Escalade. The block was empty — the guitar shop closed, the storefronts shut, the street bare. Still full daylight, the sun slanting over the rooflines to the west. He walked the forty yards back through the gap and reached the Volvo.

The bag went in the trunk. He got in the car and pulled away from the curb.

He drove south on the avenue, then west, merging into Friday evening traffic on West End. Cars going to dinner, to bars, to wherever people went on a warm night in Nashville. Dan held the speed limit and used his signals. At the bridge on Harding Place he waited for a gap in the traffic, stopped, and dropped the duffel over the railing into the creek. The road was empty for the moment and it took less than five seconds.

He drove home. The apartment was dark when he let himself in. He turned on the kitchen light and stood at the counter for a minute without doing

anything. The notebook was on the table where he'd left it. Every page in it had been filled for someone else's reasons — a route, a pattern, a stranger's week laid out toward a night like this one.

He didn't open it. There was nothing left to write.

Dan washed his hands and dried them on the dish towel hanging from the oven handle. He hung the towel back in the same spot. The Glock was still in his jacket pocket. He took it out, walked to the spare bedroom, unlocked the deadbolt, and put the gun back in its case.

He locked the door behind him and put the key on the frame.

Chapter 28 — Cleared

Travis woke in the guest room to the sound of his mother in the kitchen. Cabinets opening, the coffee maker cycling, something heavy set down on the counter — a cast-iron skillet, probably. He lay there for a minute and listened. The mattress was the same one he'd slept on in high school, soft in the middle, and he'd slept straight through for the first time in weeks.

He'd driven down Friday afternoon, a last-minute decision that wasn't really last-minute — his mother had been asking since the mistrial, every call, every pot roast and guest room and “your father said he'd clean it.” He'd finally said yes because the bungalow had gone still and the days were too long and he'd run out of things to clean. He'd called her Friday morning to say he was coming, and when he pulled into the carport next to his father's Ford at half past four, the pot roast was already in the oven and his mother was out the door before he'd turned off the engine.

The pot roast had been good. His father had asked about the Tacoma's mileage and whether the tires were the originals. His mother had talked about the tomato cages and a woman at church who was having knee surgery. Nobody mentioned the trial. They ate at the kitchen table with the television off and Travis had seconds because his mother was watching and it was easier than explaining that his appetite had been gone for a month.

He got up and found coffee in the kitchen. His mother was at the stove, scrambling eggs, already dressed, moving fast and efficient, thirty years of practice in every motion — the contained energy of a woman whose house ran on her schedule and nobody else's.

“Eggs in two minutes,” she said without turning around. “Your father's in the carport.”

Travis took his coffee to the living room. The television was on — his mother's habit, Channel 4 for the local news and weather, volume low enough to ignore but loud enough to hear if something caught your ear. He sat on the couch and watched without watching. A traffic report. A ribbon-cutting at a school. The weather — sunny, mid-eighties, the usual.

Then the anchor said “Music Row” and Travis looked up.

A Nashville developer had been found dead Friday evening at a building on the Music Row corridor. Shot. Police were on scene. The victim's name was being withheld pending notification of family. The building was part of a development project that had been the subject of recent legal proceedings. No suspects, no arrests. Anyone with information was asked to call Crime Stoppers.

The footage showed a brown brick building behind yellow tape, police vehicles angled in a parking lot. Then the camera pulled back and Travis saw the construction fence with the banner — HARMONY RIDGE DEVELOPMENT — and his hands went still on the coffee mug. He knew that fence. He knew those buildings. He'd stood on that block with a clipboard and a site map two years ago, before any of this started.

The victim's name was being withheld. Travis watched until the anchor moved on to a house fire in Antioch, then he went to the kitchen.

"Something happen?" his mother said, setting his plate down.

"Not sure yet." He sat and picked up his fork. "Maybe."

Pat called at two. Travis was on the porch, sitting in one of the metal chairs his parents had owned since before he was born, watching his father do something under the hood of the Ford. The call came to his cell — the only phone he'd brought.

"How are you doing," Pat said. Not a question exactly, more like clearing his throat before the reason he'd called.

"I'm in Murfreesboro. My parents' place."

"Good. Listen — I met with Barr yesterday morning. Walked her through everything. The corporate filings, your testimony about the Kinsey call, the Carsten chain. She took it to the DA's office yesterday afternoon."

Travis set his coffee on the arm of the chair. The metal was warm from the sun. "What did they say?"

“Caldwell’s office is reviewing it. That’s all Barr would tell me, but she didn’t sound worried. It’s solid, Travis. The Kinsey call, the financial trail, the engagement letter connecting Ruhl to Kinsey going back eighteen months. It’s a package.”

“Ruhl.”

“Victor Ruhl. Sole principal of Carsten Properties. The man behind the development.”

Travis looked at the Ford, the hood up, his father’s boots visible underneath. The brown brick building on the television that morning. The construction fence with the banner. Music Row.

“I saw something on the news this morning,” Travis said. “A developer shot at a building on Music Row. They showed the Harmony Ridge fence. They didn’t release a name.”

“I saw it too,” Pat said. “I don’t know more than what’s on the air. But if the building is Ruhl’s — and I think it is — then the man behind all of this is dead.”

Travis didn’t say anything. He held the phone and looked at the yard and felt the ground shift under him, slow and irreversible, like something that had been leaning for a long time finally falling over.

“When did you get down to your folks’ place?” Pat said.

“Friday afternoon. Four-thirty, about.”

“Anybody see you besides your parents?”

The question sat there a moment before Travis understood it, and then he understood it all the way down. “The neighbor across the road was at his mailbox when I pulled in. We ate at six.” He stopped. “They’re going to look at me for this.”

“They have to,” Pat said. “Man you had public trouble with turns up shot, you’re the first box they check. It’s a formality — you were an hour away in front of witnesses before the sun went down. When a detective calls, you give him exactly what you just gave me, nothing more, and then you give him Barr’s number. Don’t improvise.”

“Okay.”

“Barr’s going to call you,” Pat said. “Probably today. I wanted you to hear it from me first — things are moving. Whatever happens with the Ruhl situation, the evidence we built is in Caldwell’s hands and it’s not going away.”

“Okay.”

“Sit tight. Let Barr handle the next part.”

Travis hung up and put the phone on his knee. His father had come out from under the hood and was wiping his hands on a rag, squinting at something on the engine block. Down the road, a truck held its speed through the curve and was gone. The vegetable garden was bright green in the afternoon light, the tomato cages standing in neat rows.

Victor Ruhl. The name had been in the corporate filings that came out during the trial — Defense Exhibit Four, the records Travis had never seen until Barr entered them. Carsten Properties, sole principal Victor Ruhl. The man who owned the development, who had hired Kinsey, who had built the project that Travis had tried to slow down. And now he was dead in a building thirty yards from where Crown Recording had been — where Roosevelt Hayes had played bass and Marian Telford had recorded the voice that sang at the March on Washington.

Travis didn’t know what to do with that. He sat on his parents’ porch in the sun and held it without trying to shape it into anything.

Barr called at six-fifteen. Travis was in the kitchen helping his mother wash dishes — he washed, she dried, the arrangement they’d had since he was tall enough to reach the faucet.

“Travis. Are you sitting down?”

“I’m standing at a sink. What is it?”

“Caldwell’s office called me an hour ago. They’re declining to refile. The charges against you are being dropped.”

Travis turned off the water. His mother looked at him, dish towel in her hand.

“On a Saturday?” It was all he could think to say.

“They’ve had Pat’s package since yesterday afternoon, and my read is Caldwell saw where it pointed before he went home last night. Then Ruhl turned up dead, and whatever appetite he had left for a retrial went with him. He called me himself, Travis. He didn’t apologize, but he called me himself.”

“They’re also opening an investigation into Carsten Properties in connection with the Kinsey murder. The corporate filings, the financial trail, the phone call you told me about the night Hayes testified — Caldwell’s office is treating it as new evidence of an alternate suspect. There’s going to be press coverage, Travis. Your name is going to be cleared publicly. Not just charges dropped — the actual story is going to come out.”

“When?”

“Monday or Tuesday. Caldwell’s office is coordinating with the Ruhl homicide investigation — there’s overlap, and they want to get their ducks in a row before it hits the papers. But it’s happening. And expect a call from the detectives working the Ruhl case — they’ll want to know where you were Friday evening. Routine elimination, and I’ll be on the line with you when it happens. You were in Murfreesboro in front of witnesses, so it will be short.”

Travis leaned against the counter. The dish towel was over his mother’s shoulder now and her hand was on his arm, gripping, though she didn’t know yet what she was gripping for.

“Where are you right now?” Barr said.

“Murfreesboro. My parents’ house. I drove down yesterday.”

“Good. Stay there tonight. Come back tomorrow morning — I’ll need you in Nashville by noon. We should talk before the press coverage hits.”

“Okay.”

“Travis.” Barr paused, and for the first time in all the months he’d known her, the professional surface cracked just enough for something warm to come through. “This is the right result. I’ll see you tomorrow.”

She hung up. Travis set the phone on the counter and looked at his mother.

“The charges are being dropped,” he said. “They’re opening an investigation into the people who did this. It’s going to be in the news.”

His mother put both hands on the edge of the counter and pressed down like she needed something solid underneath her. She didn’t say anything for a few seconds. Then she turned and walked to the back door and opened it.

“Jim,” she called across the yard. “Come inside.”

His father came in through the back door with the rag still in his hand. He looked at his wife, then at Travis. His mother said, “Tell him,” and Travis told him. His father listened standing up, the way he listened to everything — still, arms at his sides, the rag hanging from one fist. When Travis finished, his father nodded once and then he put his hand on the back of Travis’s neck and held it there. He didn’t say anything. He didn’t need to.

His mother made a sound that was halfway between a laugh and something else and sat down hard in the kitchen chair. “I’m going to call your aunt,” she said, and then she didn’t move.

Travis lay in the guest room in the dark. The house had settled — his parents had gone to bed an hour ago after his mother called her sister and her best friend and the woman from church who was having knee surgery, in that order. His father had sat in his recliner through all of it, watching the ten o’clock news with the volume low, and when his mother finally put the phone down he’d turned off the television and said “Good night, son” and that was the most words he’d spoken all evening.

The room was small — a single bed, a dresser, a window that looked out on the carport. The same room Travis had slept in until he left for college, though his mother had replaced the bedspread and taken down the posters

years ago. The mattress still dipped in the middle. The closet still had the creak.

He could hear the Ford ticking outside as it cooled, and beyond that the deep quiet of a road where nothing moved after ten. Back in Nashville, the bungalow was dark. The deadbolt his mother had tried to pay for was holding the door shut on an empty house. The bicycle was on the porch with its rusted chain. The nightstand drawer was still empty and always would be.

But Caldwell was dropping the charges. Barr was preparing for press. On Monday or Tuesday, the Tennessean would run a story that said what Travis had known since the arrest — that he'd been framed by the people he'd tried to hold accountable, and the system had almost let them get away with it.

He thought about going back to work. Walking into city hall, badge on the lanyard, the security guard nodding him through. The people in the hallway who'd stopped waving. He'd find out which ones started again.

Travis turned on his side and looked at the window. The carport light was on — his father always left it on when Travis's truck was in the driveway. The orange glow came through the curtain and made a rectangle on the wall above the dresser, the same shape it had made every night of his childhood.

He closed his eyes. Tomorrow he'd drive back to Nashville. Barr would be waiting. The news would break. His name would mean what it used to mean, or close enough.

The house settled around him, and Travis Boone slept.

Chapter 29 — Resumption

The broker called Tuesday morning. Dan was in the Volvo, parked in the faculty lot, eating a granola bar before his eleven o'clock class.

"Wanted to close the loop on Nashville," the broker said. Same voice, same register — a man reviewing a spreadsheet.

"Go ahead."

"Client's no longer in the picture. You probably saw it on the news."

"I saw it."

"Nobody's stepping in to pick up the contract. No authorization, no funding, no point. File's closed on our end."

Dan ate the last of the granola bar and folded the wrapper. "Works for me."

"Funny timing," the broker said. "You ask me for a week, and the week's barely started when the client turns up on the evening news."

"He made a lot of people unhappy," Dan said. "Somebody got there first."

The line went still for a second. The broker didn't usually leave silence on a line. "Somebody did," he said. "Anything you need on your side?"

"No. But let's keep things out of my backyard from now on. This one got complicated."

"Local jobs usually do." The broker said it without judgment — an observation from experience, not a criticism. "Noted. Anything else?"

"That's it."

"Take care."

The line went dead. Dan put the prepaid back in the glove box and got out of the car.

Furman Hall was the same. The high ceilings, the radiators that clanked even when they weren't running, the hallway smell of old wood and floor

wax. Dan walked past the department office and Sheila looked up from her desk.

“Grades are due a week from Friday,” she said.

“I know.”

“I’m telling everyone. Don’t take it personally.”

He went to his office at the far end of the hall and unlocked the door. The desk was as he’d left it — a chipped mug holding pens, a stack of papers he’d been putting off, the interlibrary loan dissertation he’d brought back in, still lying on the corner with its dog-eared pages. He sat down and opened his laptop and spent forty minutes answering emails from students who wanted to know if the final was cumulative.

At eleven he taught his summer section. Cold War containment policy, the Truman Doctrine, the gap between public rhetoric and covert action. Fourteen students, most of them paying attention. Tyler Beckham, whose C-minus hadn’t survived the spring final, was back for a second try, in the back row with his cap turned backward, writing something that was probably not notes. Dan talked for fifty minutes, answered two questions, and dismissed them five minutes early.

He walked back to his office and sat with the door open for an hour in case anyone came by. Nobody did.

Pat called the university phone at two-thirty. Dan closed the office door.

“Closing the file,” Pat said. “Unless you’ve got something else for me.”

“Nothing else.”

“Two detectives came by this morning. The Ruhl thing — they’re working through everybody who’d been asking questions about Carsten Properties, and my name was on that list. Which is the point of the list. They asked who my client was.”

“And?”

“I gave them what I give everybody. Client’s confidential, here’s my attorney’s number, and they’re welcome to everything I handed the DA’s

office — which they already had.” A pause. “They’ll come back with a subpoena or they won’t. There’s nothing in the file but public records and interview notes.”

“The retainer?”

“Cash. I keep terrible books, Dan. It’s a character flaw.” Another pause. “One more thing. If anybody ever asks me about you — you’re a professor I have a drink with a couple times a year. You buy, I talk, neither of us remembers what about.”

“That’s accurate,” Dan said.

“That’s why it works.” Pat hung up.

Dan sat with the phone in his hand. His number was in Pat’s call log: this phone, with his name on the account and the university’s on the bill. A string of calls in both directions, starting in the middle of a murder trial he’d sat on as a juror. Nobody would pull Pat’s records without a reason, and Pat’s lawyer stood between the detectives and any reason they might find. But the number was there, and it would stay there. In all his years of work he had never left his own name at the edge of a job. He’d left it on this one because this one was his. He decided he could live with that, and found that he meant it.

He drove home and put the prepaid in the kitchen drawer and changed his shirt. Then he walked to the Thai place.

It was half full when he got there at six. The woman behind the counter nodded when he came in and started his order — she already knew. He sat at the small table near the window and waited.

The television above the counter was on Channel 4, the volume low. A commercial, then the local news. Dan let it run at the edge of his attention — traffic, a rezoning dispute in Germantown, the weather.

Then Travis Boone’s face was on the screen.

The anchor read the story over a photo — Travis in a suit, the courthouse steps behind him. Charges dropped. DA's office investigating Carsten Properties in connection with the Kinsey murder. New evidence of corporate conspiracy, alternate suspects. The anchor said Travis Boone had been publicly cleared of all charges and was expected to return to his position with the Metropolitan Planning Commission.

The footage cut to Travis outside the courthouse — different day, different suit, his parents beside him. His mother was holding his arm. His father stood slightly behind, tall, still, looking straight ahead. Travis said something to a reporter that Dan couldn't hear over the restaurant noise. He looked tired but he was standing straight and his hands were steady.

Dan had been hired to end that man. Instead he was on the screen with his hands steady and his parents beside him, alive and cleared — and the only person who would ever know how that had come to pass was sitting alone at a corner two-top, waiting on his usual. It was the closest thing to a result the work ever gave back, and it arrived the way most things did now: quiet, on a television turned too low to hear, with no one to tell.

The woman brought Dan's plate — green curry, same as always. He picked up his fork and ate. On the screen, the story moved to the Ruhl homicide investigation — ongoing, no arrests, multiple leads being pursued. Then the weather came back on.

Dan finished his food and left cash on the table. The woman behind the counter said good night, eyes still on her phone.

He walked the four blocks home in the warm air. The streetlights were on. A couple passed him on the sidewalk, laughing about something. A dog barked from a second-floor window. Nashville on a Tuesday evening, the same as it was last week and the week before and every week since Dan had moved here.

In the apartment, he opened the kitchen drawer and took out the prepaid. No missed calls, no messages. He put it back next to the coffee filters and closed the drawer.

The university phone was on the counter. He picked it up and scrolled through — two emails from students, a department reminder about grades, a text from his sister: *Call me when you get a chance. Nothing urgent.*

He turned on the television in the living room. The news was still running — a different channel, the same Travis Boone story, the same courthouse footage. Dan watched it for a few seconds, then his sister's text caught his eye again and he picked up the phone and called her.

"Hey," she said. "How's summer school?"

"Almost done. Finals next week."

"Are you eating?"

"Just got back from the Thai place."

"The same Thai place? You need to branch out."

Dan turned off the television. On the screen, Travis Boone disappeared mid-sentence.

"How's the new job?" Dan said.

She told him. It was fine — the commute was longer but the people were better, and her boss actually read her emails before replying to them, which was apparently a low bar that her previous employer had failed to clear. Dan listened and asked a question and listened some more. They talked for eight minutes about nothing that mattered and everything that did.

"I should let you go," she said. "You sound tired."

"I'm fine."

"Call me this weekend?"

"Yeah."

He hung up and set the phone on the counter. The refrigerator cycled on and filled the room with its low hum. Through the living room window, the streetlight on the corner made its circle on the sidewalk below. Nobody walked through it.

Dan went to the living room and picked up the paperback from the arm of the couch — the one from McKay's, the one he'd been reading without retaining much. He read for half an hour and this time the words stayed.

He set the book facedown on the cushion and got up. He walked to the spare bedroom at the end of the hall, reached up to the door frame, and found the key. He tried the deadbolt. Locked. He put the key back and went to brush his teeth.

The apartment was dark when he got into bed. He could hear the building's pipes through the wall, and beyond them the low hum of the city that had been his home for eleven years. He closed his eyes.

The prepaid phone was in the drawer. The key was on the frame. The summer session was almost over and the fall semester would start in August and Dan Mercer would be there to teach it.

